

THE QILVAYAS SYMPHONY

A Dungeons & Dragons 5th Edition Campaign Setting

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"I gaze upon the night sky admiring the stars strewn across Heaven's field. Each one a testament of power, its light piercing through the void to shine upon us. And now to our dawn light I summon you. Lord, have mercy upon us sinful children of Zhuvedus. Give us your light, Lord...and give me my destiny. I am Qilvayas, Emperor of the Zhuvedians. We are the Kin of Great Timberwolf."

—Prayer of Qilvayas on the eve of his coronation

CAMPAIGN OVERVIEW

The Qilvayas Symphony is a campaign of imperial ambition, prophetic visions, and moral complexity set against the backdrop of a crumbling empire. Drawing inspiration from Byzantine history — particularly the struggles of emperors like Justinian who sought to restore former Roman glory — this campaign explores themes of legacy, power, the cost of idealism, and the tension between the dream of unity and the reality of a fractured world.

The player characters are final-year students at the prestigious Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne, completing their field exercises and planning their futures as independent adventurers. When they receive a shared prophetic vision of the capital city in flames and a monstrous shadow in storm clouds above, they are drawn into events that will test their abilities, challenge their loyalties, and potentially determine the fate of the empire itself.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

THE HEIGHT OF EMPIRE

At its zenith, the Empire of Zhuvedus spanned nearly an entire continent. United under the Lupine Throne and guided by the principles of the Lupine Matron, the empire represented civilization, law, and order. The Golden Tablets — sacred legal codes established by the empire's forefathers — formed the foundation of Zhuvedian governance and culture. Trade flourished along imperial roads, justice was administered by trained magistrates, and the imperial legions defended the borders against external threats.

The imperial capital, seat of the Lupine Throne, was the beating heart of this civilization — a center of learning, culture, and power that drew the ambitious and talented from across the realm.

TWO CENTURIES OF DECLINE

The empire's decline was not sudden but gradual — a slow erosion over two hundred years. Internal strife between noble houses weakened central authority. Corruption spread through the bureaucracy as distant provinces found ways to avoid imperial taxation and oversight. Military expeditions to reclaim lost territories or suppress rebellions failed, draining the treasury and damaging the legions' reputation. External powers, sensing weakness, pressed against the borders and even seized imperial territory.

Most devastatingly, the empire fractured. What had been provinces became semi-independent "nations," each ruled by ambitious warlords, merchant councils, or noble houses who once swore fealty to the throne but now pursued their own interests. Some maintained the fiction of imperial loyalty while ignoring imperial law. Others openly declared independence. Still others warred among themselves, creating a patchwork of competing powers where once there had been unity.

The imperial capital remained, and the Lupine Throne was still occupied, but the reach of imperial authority had shrunk dramatically. The empire existed more in memory and aspiration than in reality.

THE EMPIRE OF ZHUVEDUS: CURRENT STATE

POLITICAL LANDSCAPE

The empire today is a shadow of its former self, yet it persists. The imperial capital and its surrounding territories remain under direct imperial control, and several regions still recognize the Lupine Throne's authority — some genuinely, others opportunistically. The fractured "nations" present a complex political landscape:

Border Lords and Regional Powers: Former provincial governors, military commanders, and noble houses now rule territories as de facto independent states. Their relationship with the throne varies — some maintain nominal loyalty while ignoring imperial edicts, others have declared independence outright, and a few actively work against reunification to protect their autonomy.

Merchant Republics: Wealthy trading cities that broke away to avoid imperial taxation, now governed by councils of merchants and guild masters. They prefer the current disorder, which allows them to play different powers against each other for commercial advantage.

Warlord Territories: Regions held by military strongmen who rose to power during the empire's collapse. Some style themselves as protectors of order, others are little better than bandits with armies.

Imperial Loyalists: Territories that still genuinely support the throne, either out of tradition, religious conviction in the Lupine Matron's divine mandate, or pragmatic belief that a restored empire offers better stability than the current chaos.

The borders are fluid and contested. Alliances shift, minor wars flare up and sputter out, and ambitious lords constantly scheme for advantage. Into this volatile situation steps Emperor Qilvayas with his vision of restoration.

ATLAS OF THE FRACTURED EMPIRE

The territories below are the ones most likely to matter in the campaign's first arcs — not an exhaustive map. Distances by imperial road: the Ostmark is four days east of Aenodira, the Brekelands roughly two weeks west, Tarnovar three weeks into the western highlands, Velmareth ten days downriver.

The Crownlands: The imperial core — Aenodira, its river valley, and the districts within a week's march — under direct rule and the only place imperial law functions at full strength. Prosperous by current standards, anxious by any other measure: everyone in the Crownlands lives inside the restoration project, whether they believe in it or not. Capital culture runs on the race-days of the Long Course, where the city's two great factions — the Golds and the Greys, named for the stone of the walls they claim — turn sport into politics and politics into sport (see Plot Hooks: The Grey-Gold Rising).

The Ostmark: The eastern march, held by thin legion garrisons and thick tradition. Loyalist by conviction in the towns (Dravenna among them) and by inertia in the countryside. The Third Provincial Legion scandal — Colonel Aurel Dessen, who sold his garrison's grain and blamed the men who fled — is exactly the kind of rot that decides whether places like this stay loyal. Magistrate Cassivar Ondrei's complaint about it is somewhere in a capital inbox. The march's pride, and the throne's quiet anxiety, is Marshal Gavric Dane (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire), the young commander who brought a lost wolf-standard home.

The Suthmark: The southern breadbasket, genuinely loyalist and deeply devout — the Matron's faith runs older and plainer here than in the capital: harvest processions, field-shrines, saints' days kept by planting calendars. Governed by the ducal house of Vasq — the young Duke Aldous in law, and his mother the Dowager Duchess Emerenn in fact (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire), Velmareth-born and iron beneath the mourning silk, whose loyalty is sincere and whose patience is not unlimited. The south still carries two scars it does not discuss with outsiders: the Vintage Night, six years past, and the hill country around Castle Greywell, where servant girls have a way of not coming home.

Principality of Tarnovar: A highland nation in the far west, openly independent for a century and pointedly uninterested in reunification. Tarnovari culture is built on the given word: oaths are sworn on standing stones rather than gods, oath-breaking is the one unforgivable crime, and their oldest ballads mourn a betrayed lord called Vosthren, whose story no imperial scholar has ever bothered to trace. Their proverb for treating with the throne: "Never again the wolf's word." Ruled by the aging, canny Voivode Ysavet Morn — whose word is absolute everywhere except the Eastmarch, where her kinsman Ban Dregan Morn keeps the border with the

Brekelands by methods she has never sanctioned and never stopped (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire).

DM Only: Tarnovar is what became of Threnvos's people. "Vosthren" is Threnvos, syllable-inverted by twenty centuries of oral drift — a name the Church never thought to suppress because it never recognized it. The Tarnovari do not know their own true origin; their stone-oath customs and their instinctive distrust of imperial promises are cultural scar tissue from a wound no living person can name. This is a mid-campaign revelation of enormous weight: proof of the buried founding account exists in living culture, not just old stones — and depending on how it surfaces, Tarnovar becomes the empire's natural ally against the shadow or the rightful claimant its founding wronged. Handle with care; do not spend it early.

Free City of Velmareth and the Delta Compact: The great merchant republic of the river delta and the league of trading towns in its orbit. Rich, ostentatiously neutral, and quietly committed to the fractured status quo — disorder is margin. The Merchant Republic delegations at Aenodira's Exchange answer, eventually, to Velmareth's Harborlords — among whose great banking houses the Meldane name still opens every door, a fact of continuing relevance to the Suthmark (see Duchess Emerenn Vasq).

The Brekelands: The broken middle-west: a patchwork of warlord holdings where imperial administration simply stopped. The local trouble is the Granary War — warlords Bettra Skarn and Ilmarch Voss burning each other's villages over a dispute neither remembers clearly — which produced the Halvenne refugees and three other burned villages this season. But the Granary War is a squabble between men who cannot see the weather coming: from the west, Duke Garvin Norr absorbs one warlord holding after another into Normere's Reckoning Book, and along the eastern hills runs Ban Dregan's Fence, which no Brekeland company raids past twice.

The See of Orlath: A breakaway patriarchate in the north claiming the purer doctrine of the Matron — founded nearly sixty years ago by Saint-Regent Olvesa the Reconciled (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire), a woman whose road to sanctity ran through one of the most terrible vengeance in northern memory. Orlath recognizes neither the Matriarchate's authority nor the Office of Omens' monopoly on the divine will, and refugees of conscience — clergy who fell out with the Sanctum — drift there still. What the capital has not yet understood: Orlath is no longer merely a schism. It is preparing a coronation — and when the crown is set, Olvesa's sixty-year regency ends, its whole purpose discharged.

Kingdom of Ardven: The young power of the far north, beyond Orlath: a dozen quarrelsome kingdoms and clanlands hammered into one crown over fifteen years by King Karvel (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire). Ardven is expansionist, literate, and increasingly confident — Karvel plants monastery schools the way other kings plant fortresses, and his court hosts scholars the empire's academies lost to poverty or politics. His consolidation of the northern coasts has had one consequence the empire feels directly: the ship-clans of the Skellvard, driven from fjords they held for generations, now raid southward with nowhere to return to.

The Skellvard: Sea-lords raiding the imperial coast in growing strength — but raiders is only half the truth. The Skell ship-clans are a displaced people, pushed from their

northern harbors by Ardven's expansion, led by Sea-King Aldrec the Landless (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire), who once served the empire and was cheated for it. Skell culture keeps tally-sticks of every debt owed and every promise broken; their raids are recorded, clan by clan, as collections. Their kings are buried beneath rivers, in secret, so that no enemy may ever stand on a Skell king's grave — a people whose deepest fear is having nowhere to be buried at all.

The Duchy of Normere: The iron surprise of the west coast: a once-minor duchy forged into the most efficient state in the fractured empire by Duke Garvin Norr, the Bastard of Normere (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire). Normere's instruments are famous and feared in equal measure — the Reckoning Book, a census of every hide of land and head of livestock the Duke rules; the personal oath every landholder swears to Norr himself, bypassing all intermediate lords; and the memory of the Harrowing of the Weld, four years past, when a rebellious district learned what the Duke's patience costs when it runs out. Norr is not resisting reunification. He is conducting his own.

IMPERIAL AND BORDER JURISDICTION, AT A GLANCE

Imperial law does not mean the same thing twice past the Crownlands' border. The table below is a single page for a question the Atlas otherwise answers one region at a time: where the Laws actually run, and who actually enforces whatever does.

Region	Status	Who Actually Enforces
The Crownlands	Direct Rule — imperial law at full strength	The Palatine Guard; imperial magistrates
The Ostmark	Loyalist Provincial — nominal, unevenly enforced	Thin legion garrisons; Magistrate Ondrei's model
The Suthmark	Loyalist Provincial — genuinely loyal, governed through the ducal house	Duke Aldous in law; the Dowager Duchess's household authority in fact, alongside the Church
Principality of Tarnovar	Sovereign Treaty-Nation — imperial law does not apply	Oath-custom; the Voivode; Ban Dregan's Fence (unsanctioned even internally)
Velmareth and the Delta Compact	Sovereign Treaty-Nation — own mercantile law; the Marked hold actual legal standing here, uniquely	The Harborlords; the Compact's own courts
The Brekelands	Contested / Warlord — imperial statute on the books, unenforced	Individual warlords; no appeal exists

Region	Status	Who Actually Enforces
The See of Orlath	Parallel Legal-Religious Authority — rejects the Matriarchate and the Office of Omens alike	Olvesa's See; its own rival Sanction
Kingdom of Ardven	Sovereign Treaty-Nation — an independent, literate, expansionist crown	King Karvel's own developing law
The Skellvard	Non-Territorial Customary Law — no fixed land, no codified statute	Clan lawspeakers; tally-sticks record debts and broken promises
The Duchy of Normere	De Facto Replacement — imperial law formally claimed, functionally superseded	Duke Norr's personal-oath system and the Reckoning Book

One exception is worth flagging rather than generalizing: Velmareth's grant of legal standing to the Marked has no imperial equivalent, and whether it ever becomes one is a live question the Zhuvedian Laws do not yet answer.

THE REGIONS IN DEPTH

Per the approved full-fantasy dial: monsters are common, dragons are active, and the wild is genuinely wild. Creature lists name SRD monsters except where a name is followed by a bracketed dagger — (†) — which marks a Monster Manual creature outside the SRD, to be looked up rather than pulled from the open data. Each region: the land, who lives there, what hunts there, and named settlements.

THE CROWNLANDS

The land: the Ostrun's broad valley — terraced grain, cypress windbreaks, poplar-lined imperial roads, and the capital's three walls rising out of river haze. Old, worked, beautiful, tired. Peoples: Zhuvedian humans, Coppergate halflings, the masons' dwarves, faded high-elf houses, the Craft's gnomes — and the dynasty, alone in its blood. Creatures: mostly human dragons, plus the city's famous exceptions — wererats (†) in Rivergate's deep cellars (the Watch denies it; the Inkhands charge a surcharge for jobs below the waterline), the Garrison's last three griffons (the wing was forty strong at the height of empire; the riders' hall keeps every empty saddle oiled), and the wolves of Aenodira — sacred, protected, and (DM only) leaving the Old Forum district family by family for three years. Settlements: Aenodira (canon); Varn's Crossing (canon — the toll bridge); Lupenna, a pilgrim town at the Matron's first roadside shrine, all candle-stalls and wolf-icons; Whitequay, a river town that ships the valley's grain and remembers when it shipped ten times more.

THE OSTMARK

The land: big-sky plains breaking into wooded hills eastward, watch-forts on the heights (Redwatch was one of a chain — most now stand empty), and the trade road

running through it all like a nerve. Peoples: Ostfolk humans and the marches' respected half-orc veteran families; a legion culture even where the legions are thin. Creatures: wolf packs (read for omens), worgs where the old auxiliary kennels went feral, ogres in the hill country, ankhegs in the grain flats, griffons nesting the crags (the legions once took eggs under license; nobody has dared in a generation), and wights (†) and worse in the failed watch-forts — dead garrisons make bad neighbors, and the shadow's stirring is making them restless. Settlements: Dravenna (canon); Kolvess, the Third Legion's garrison town, where Colonel Dessen's name is said carefully; Serren's Mill, a crossroads village famous for poppy-milk and for minding its own business.

THE SUTHMARK

The land: golden grain to the horizon, vineyard terraces, chalk downs, and — eastward — the grey hollows of the Greywell hills, where the light arrives late and leaves early. Peoples: devout Suthfolk humans, halfling harvest-clans, hill dwarves in the east (whose families have learned the valley's law does not climb). Creatures: ankhegs (the grain country's classic plague — harvest-festival effigies are shaped like them), giant boars, blights in the old orchards, a confirmed green hag somewhere in the Greywell watershed (the valley folk leave her be, on the reasonable grounds that she is not the worst thing in those hills), and harvest-fey of the Old Observance — sprites and a dryad grove the Church politely does not discuss. Settlements: Caldessa, the ducal seat — wine, mourning-silk, and the Garland's quiet ears in every kitchen; Ambervale, a harvest town that hosts the south's great festival (and was one of the three towns of the Vintage Night — the festival has a new route now, avoiding certain streets); Greywell-under-Hill, the village at the castle's feet, where the wages are good.

PRINCIPALITY OF TARNOVAR

The land: the empire's deep wilderness — montane mist-forest rising to bare stone, the standing-stone rings on the bald summits, valleys where noon looks like evening. The Old Wood at its heart is the largest unbroken forest in the fractured world. Peoples: Tarnovari humans and the Stonesworn dwarves (a third of the nation, fully Tarnovari), wood-elf communities deep in the Old Wood keeping the eldest ballads — including, unknowing, the truest ones. Creatures: owlbears, ettercaps and their webs in the pine deeps, green hags at the fey margins, elk and giant elk, winter wolves on the high passes — and the Old Wood's fey-touched heart, where the Hollow Hills stand and travelers' time runs strange (a soft Feywild adjacency, never named onstage). Settlements: Kamenhold, the Voivode's seat, built dry-stone into a mountainside — the oath-stones of every Tarnovari family stand in its high field; Fencegate, Ban Dregan's border fort on the Eastmarch, beyond which the stakes begin; Verath, an Old Wood village of singers — Ilinca's home — where the Lament cycle is kept whole.

FREE CITY OF VELMARETH AND THE DELTA COMPACT

The land: the Ostrun's delta — reed-seas, tidal channels, and the lagoon city itself: Velmareth on its ten thousand pilings, all bridges, salt-stained marble, and money. Peoples: everyone — the true cosmopolis; Velmarene humans and half-elves, halfling middle guilds, Marked (tiefeling) quarters with actual legal standing, Sarkanni mercenary lodges, and anything the tide brings. Creatures: giant crocodiles in the reed-sea, merrow in the outer channels (the Compact pays a

'channel-toll' it does not describe in its ledgers), water elementals bound as harbor-engines by chartered thaumatarges, swarms of everything — and, in the drowned quarter's oldest cellars, things the Harborlords' dredge-teams are paid triple to not discuss. Settlements: Velmareth itself; Saltmark, the Compact's toll-town at the delta mouth; Reedhaven, a stilt-village of pilots and smugglers who are often the same families.

THE BREKELANDS

The land: broken hill country — hedgerows gone wild between burned granges, mill-streams turning no wheels, roads that fork around the ruins of villages that were the reason for the roads. Peoples: Brekelander humans — tough, displaced, warlord-taxed — and everyone's deserters. Creatures: the war's harvest — gnolls (famine-born packs following the burnings; the old folk say gnolls are what hunger prays to), ghouls and ghaunts at the burn sites (betrayal-fed dead: Halvenne's ashes are already whispered about), wyverns in the high crags taking cattle and the occasional tax-collector, and manticores that learned to follow armies. (**DM only:** the ghoule-density at parley-breach sites is not natural, and it is rising. The Brekelands are the shadow's best-fed province outside the capital.) Settlements: Skarnhold and Vosskeep, the rival warlord seats, each convinced it is the reasonable one; Millbreak, a neutral market town that survives by being useful to everyone and loyal to no one — the Brekelands in one village.

THE SEE OF ORLATH

The land: taiga edge and fell-country — pilgrim roads switchbacking to the mountain city, prayer-cairns at every false summit, and the Reconciliation Shrine above the treeline where Olvesa spent her year. Peoples: Orlathine humans — penitent, rigorous, warmer than their liturgy — and clergy refugees from every Sanctum quarrel of the last forty years. Creatures: winter wolves (Orlath reads them as the Matron's northern honor guard and feeds them at the pilgrim stations — a practice the Sanctum calls heresy and the wolves call dinner), polar bears and saber-cats on the high fells, trolls in the ravines, banshees (†) on the Drevic moors — the old clan-lands never quite finished grieving — and ice mephits in the shrine-heights. Settlements: Orlath, the see-city, carved switchback galleries and the Second Treasury of Relics; Penitent's Stair, the last town before the Shrine, economy of candles, crutches, and confessions; Drevholm, the quiet town on the old clan-lands, where nobody sings.

KINGDOM OF ARDVEN

The land: fjords and pine-clad steepes, longhouse towns turning to slate-roofed monastery burghs as Karvel's new order spreads — the north mid-transformation, timber to stone, saga to script. Peoples: Ardvenner humans, wood-elf enclaves in the wilds, dwarven quarry-towns under royal charter. Creatures: the Fjell Whites — a brood of young white dragons in the high ranges that Karvel's rangers cull like wolves-of-state (an adult matriarch is unconfirmed; the rangers' silence on the question is its own answer); frost giants in the far fells, with whom Karvel maintains a tribute-truce he finds humiliating and keeps anyway; trolls, winter wolves, mammoths on the tundra edge; and giant eagles that the northern kings once flew — Karvel is trying to revive the mews, because of course he is. Settlements: Karvholm, the new capital — half longhouse, half cathedral, all ambition; Lettervik, the monastery town where forty schools' worth of scribes are teaching the north to write; Fjellgard, the ranger

town under the dragon-fells, quietly the toughest place in the kingdom.

THE SKELLVARD

The land: not land — the cold sea itself, island anchorages, whale-roads, and the drowned fjords the clans lost to Ardven’s expansion. The Skell live aboard; the fleets are the nation. Peoples: Skell humans — salt-cured, tally-keeping, courteous in the way of people who remember everything. Creatures: hunter sharks and killer whales (clan-omens), merrow war-bands (old enemies, old treaties), harpies on the guano stacks, a plesiosaurus breed the clans call sea-elk and herd — herd — and, beneath the Weeping Strait, the Saltmaw (see Part VI). Settlements (such as they are): the Gathering Roads, the great fleet-moot in the lee of the Broken Isles, a city that exists two months a year; Wrecksalt Isle, the beaching-ground, shipwright’s yard, and the closest thing the landless have to holy ground — no king is buried there; that is the point of it.

THE DUCHY OF NORMERE

The land: rain-lashed headlands, drained polder-fields behind the Duke’s dikes (the Reckoning Book records every sluice), slate towns of ruthless neatness, and castles placed like arguments. Peoples: Normerine humans — administered, prosperous, watchful — and hired dwarven stonewrights on chartered terms. Creatures: the coast’s merrow and sahuagin raiders (Norr’s shore-levies drill against them monthly; attendance is recorded), wights in the pre-duc al barrows (Norr’s surveyors map them and build around, to the letter of an old accommodation nobody writes down) — and the Weld. (DM only: the Harrowing left revenants (†) — vengeance-oath dead — walking the burned district. Norr knows. The Weld is the one entry in the Reckoning Book with no numbers in it, and the one place his personal oath-web has a hole in it. The shadow has noticed the hole.) Settlements: Norr’s Watch, the ducal seat — the Reckoning Book’s hall is open to any sworn subject, which is either transparency or the largest threat ever bound in vellum; Slateharrow, the naval port; the Weld, which is on the maps and off the itineraries.

DRAGONS OF THE FRACTURED AGE

VESSARKATH THE PATIENT — THE SILVASSE WEALD

Ancient green dragon (SRD), and the true author of the Silvasse Disaster: sixty years ago, three legions marched into her wood — hers for eight centuries — and she did what patience does. She has slept on their eagles ever since, which reframes canon without contradicting it: Marshal Dane’s recovery of the Ninth’s standard from ‘the Brekelands warlords’ stands — the warlords had it because Vessarkath let one standard leave her hoard, through channels, some fifty-seven years after taking it. Why she permitted it is DM-only, and now settled canon: she moved in the season the shadow beneath Aenodira stirred (see The Acceleration). A creature that has kept that wood for eight centuries feels a wound that old reopen the way lesser things feel a change in the weather, and she does not sleep through it. Marshal Dane’s legend is, without his knowing, a shadow-artifact — the standard came home because something under the

capital woke — and the one creature in the world who could ever tell him so is the dragon that felt it move. She does not raid; she does not treat; she receives. The Brekelands warlords’ unspoken western border is not Norr. It was never Norr.

THE SALTMAW — THE WEEPING STRAIT

Dragon turtle (SRD), old beyond clan-memory, dwelling beneath the strait where the empire spent three thousand Skell lives. The clans propitiate it with the salt-tithe — cargo given to the water at the strait’s mouth — and its interventions are weather to them: unpredictable, unappealable, occasionally merciful. DM-option, flagged within a flag: what the imperial admiral’s squadrons actually fled at the Weeping Strait — the battle canon leaves unspecified — may have been the Saltmaw rising. If adopted, Aldrec’s people were spent not against raiders but as a distraction offered to a leviathan, which sharpens his grievance from cruelty to sacrilege. If not adopted, the Saltmaw is simply the strait’s terrible fact and the tithe’s reason.

THE FJELL WHITES — THE ARDVEN RANGES

A brood of young white dragons (SRD) in the high north — Karvel’s standing predator-control problem, culled by the Fjellgard rangers like wolves-of-state. The unconfirmed adult matriarch is the north’s quiet dread and a ready-made mid-campaign escalation: if she exists and wakes, Ardven’s working restoration meets its first problem that cannot be administered, audited, or crowned away — timed, if the DM wishes, terribly close to the coronation.

RUMORS OF WINGS (PLAYER-FACING TEXTURE, D6)

d6	Rumor (and the truth)
1	‘Gold seen over the Velmareth delta at dusk.’ (A wyvern flock in low sun. Merchants embellish.)
2	‘The Saltmaw took a Compact grain-ship whole.’ (True. The ship had skipped the tithe two years running.)
3	‘A white wing over Karvholm itself.’ (A young Fjell White, lost in cloud, gone by morning — but Karvel doubled the rangers.)
4	‘The Silvasse eats compasses. And legions.’ (Both, in a sense, true.)
5	‘There is a dragon under Aenodira.’ (False — and the DM should let players chew this one, because what is under Aenodira is worse, and the rumor is the city’s way of almost knowing it.)
6	‘The Matron’s own wolf flies on nights of the dark moon.’ (Faith, not zoology. Probably.)

COMMERCE: SHOPS AND PRICE TABLES

All mundane prices pulled from the SRD equipment data (exact book values). Magic availability per the approved economy: Church almonries sell sanctioned mercy openly; arcane material is chartered, scarce, and papered; Rivergate discounts everything including the truth.

THE EXCHANGE, AENODIRA — GENERAL OUTFITTING (BOOK PRICES)

Item	Price	Item	Price
Backpack	2 gp	Rope, hempen (50 ft.)	1 gp
Bedroll	1 gp	Rations (1 day)	5 sp
Lantern, hooded	5 gp	Oil (flask)	1 sp
Torch	1 cp	Tinderbox	5 sp
Crowbar	2 gp	Grappling hook	2 gp
Chain (10 ft.)	5 gp	Waterskin	2 sp
Mirror, steel	5 gp	Caltrops (bag)	1 gp
Healer's Kit	5 gp	Climber's Kit	25 gp

THE GARRISON QUARTERMASTER — ARMS & ARMOR (LICENSE INSPECTED, PRICES BOOK)

Item	Price	Item	Price
Shortsword	10 gp	Longsword	15 gp
Shield	10 gp	Chain Shirt	50 gp
Breastplate	400 gp	Crossbow, light	25 gp
Arrows (20)	1 gp	Spear	1 gp

SCHOLAR'S ROW & THE CHURCH ALMONRY — THE SANCTIONED TRADE

Item	Price	Notes
Potion of Healing (stamped)	50 gp	Church almonry; the stamp is the Sanction — possession of unstamped potions invites questions
Potion of Greater Healing	200 gp	Requires standing with a parish, or a pilgrim's writ
Holy water (flask)	25 gp	Book price; Orlathine-blessed flasks trade at a premium or a discount depending on the buyer's politics
Spell scroll, 1st level	100 gp	Chartered scriptorium; purchaser entered in the register
Spell scroll, 2nd level	300 gp	As above, plus a thaumaturgical reference
Component pouch	25 gp	Book price
Ink (1 oz.) / Paper (sheet)	10 gp / 2 sp	Book prices; Scholar's Row runs on both
Spellbook (blank, bound)	50 gp	Book price
Blessed taper (homebrew, common)	5 gp	Burns 1 hour; its light counts as the light of a shrine for purposes of the Old Observance — mostly bought for funerals and promises

RIVERGATE GRAY MARKET — 'EVERYTHING CERTIFIED'

Item	Price	Notes
Any Exchange-list item	–20%	Provenance flexible; quality genuine (the Inkhands guarantee it — their ledgers are their honor)
Unstamped healing potion	35 gp	Works fine. The discount is the legal risk, priced honestly
Unlicensed scrollwork, 1st	60–80 gp	1-in-6 chance of a flawed casting (DM discretion); the good scribes cost Exchange prices anyway
'Relic' of a named saint	10–500 gp	Almost always false. Almost. (See Part I: the false-relic trade, and the terrifying occasional exception)
Dead-office seals & instruments	Negotiable	Mosse's shop — see Session Five; prices are sentimental

REGIONAL SIGNATURE VENDORS

Vendor	Where	Specialty & Sample Prices
Ostwatch Outfitters (Yanna's cousin's house)	Dravenna	Road & cold-weather gear at book; caravan intelligence free with purchase; wolf-charms 1 sp ('for luck, and it's bad luck not to')
The Stonewright's Yard	Kamenhold	Dwarven-forged tools +10% (worth it); Oathstone Charms 5 gp (see Part VIII homebrew); dry-stone masonry consulting, priced in favors
The Vintners' Hall	Caldessa	Suthmark vintages 1–50 gp; mourning-silk; and the Garland hears every order placed
The Letter-House	Lettervik	Books 25 gp+, maps of the north 10 gp, copying services; Karvel's subsidy makes literacy cheap — the point is the point
The Tithe-Factor	Saltmark	Ship passage, cargo insurance (Saltmaw exclusions in small print), Skell tally-sticks as negotiable instruments

THE LUPINE MATRON AND IMPERIAL FAITH

The Lupine Matron is the divine patron of the Zhuvedian Empire, represented as a great wolf — wise, protective, and fierce. According to Zhuvedian theology, the Lupine Matron gave the empire's people their core virtues: loyalty, honor, wisdom, and the strength to endure hardship. The phrase "We are the Kin of Great Timberwolf" references this divine connection and appears in imperial prayers and ceremonies.

The Matron's worship long predates the empire that now venerates her. Zhuvedian doctrine holds that she has guided many champions and many peoples across a span of time far longer than any dynasty's recorded history — Zhuvedus was simply the most successful and most enduring of those she chose to favor. Whether Zhuvedus himself ever attained true divinity, however, is a matter of genuine theological dispute, one that runs directly through the empire's politics and its faith alike (see The Founding Myth: Zhuvedus and the Broken Oath).

The faith of the Lupine Matron has historically unified the empire, providing moral and spiritual justification for imperial authority. The Golden Tablets, containing the fundamental laws of the empire, are said to have been inspired by the Lupine Matron's wisdom and committed to writing by the empire's forefathers.

However, as the empire fractured politically, regional variations in the faith have emerged. Some breakaway territories emphasize different aspects of the Lupine Matron's teachings or venerate local saints above imperial doctrine. This theological fragmentation mirrors the political splintering and presents both a challenge and an opportunity for Qilvayas's restoration efforts.

The Church of the Lupine Matron in the capital remains the institutional heart of the faith — wealthy, hierarchical, and deeply entangled with imperial politics. Its clergy administer doctrine, sanctify imperial authority, and guard their interpretive monopoly over omens, visions, and the divine will. Those who claim direct revelation outside Church sanction occupy dangerous ground: not quite heretical, but never fully tolerated. This tension becomes immediately relevant to the party through the Seeress (see Key NPCs and Factions).

THE CHURCH IN PRACTICE

The capital Church is governed by the Matriarchate — Matriarch Ilsevet Corvane as the Voice of the Matron in Aenodira — advised (and constrained) by the Synod of the Grey, a council of senior clergy whose sessions are closed and whose politics are not. There is no supreme authority above them, and this is a decision rather than a vacancy: the Matriarchate is collegial by design, so that no one throat holds the whole of the faith. A Prelate accordingly holds his jurisdiction from the Synod rather than from the Matriarch personally — her colleague with his own writ, not her subordinate, which is why the Office of Omens can pursue a posture she has not endorsed and cannot simply countermand. Beneath them: the seminaries of the Sanctum, the parish structure that reaches into every district and most loyalist provinces, and the Office of Omens, headed by Prelate Sarvin Odell, which claims sole authority to receive, examine, and rule on visions, portents, and claims of divine contact. The Office's method is bureaucratic rather than cruel — polite reception, separate questioning, a written determination — and its determinations have a way of ending in files rather than answers. It resents Vaelindra's existence the way a licensing board resents an unlicensed master: not because she is fraudulent, but because she is not theirs. And under Odell, resentment has recently become policy: as unsanctioned claims multiply across the fracturing empire, the Office has moved from keeping files to serving writs — its posture toward Vaelindra, and toward anyone publicly associated with her, is now active interference rather than watchful patience (engaged in Sessions Five and Six).

THE KEEPERS OF THE ASCENT (IMPERIAL CULT)

The imperial cult's formal body is small: the Keepers of the Ascent, a priesthood of perhaps forty, led by Hierophant Malzeth Corr, maintaining the dynastic shrine within Highcourt and the doctrine that Zhuvedus rose to divinity and his line carries the spark of it. The Keepers serve the throne's legitimacy and know it; the Church tolerates them and both institutions understand exactly why. Qilvayas's own relationship to the cult is correct rather than warm — he performs the dynastic rites because an emperor must, and the question of whether he privately believes them is one his court has learned not to ask.

DEATH, THE VIGIL, AND THE HALLS OF THE DEAD

Doctrine is specific about one thing across every schism, every breakaway see, every province that argues about everything else: the Matron watches the dead home, and she does it at night. No Zhuvedian burns, buries, or gives a body to the water before it has been kept through at least one full night's Vigil — watched, lit, and never left alone — because a soul let into the dark unwatched is a soul the Matron might lose track of, and doctrine is not interested in finding out whether that's literally true. This is the one funerary practice that travels unchanged from the capital's golden dome to the furthest Ardven monastery-burgh: something recognizably vigil-shaped happens everywhere, even where almost nothing else about the rite matches.

What happens after the Vigil is where the empire stops agreeing with itself, the same way it stops agreeing about everything else once you leave the Crownlands. Aenodira interns its dead in the Bone Galleries beneath the Old Forum, centuries deep, oldest at the bottom — a practice old enough to predate the Church's involvement in it. (The public stairs on the Forum's east side serve the upper galleries only; the deeper levels have been closed 'for consolidation' since before living memory, and the vigil-keepers do not ask — which keeps the funerary traffic entirely clear of the route established in Session Six.) The Suthmark folds burial into the planting calendar: the devout are put into the ground on saints' days tied to sowing or harvest, on the theory that a soul returned to the earth on the right day helps the next year's grain along. Tarnovar barely buries at all in the imperial sense — a dead Tarnovari's oaths, not their body, are what the living formally inherit, spoken aloud at the standing stones by whoever takes up the unfinished promise, while the body itself goes to the Old Wood by older and less documented means. Velmareth, characteristically, sends its dead into the reed-sea on lit barges and calls the crocodiles a hazard rather than a horror.

For an ordinary market town with no catacombs and no delta to send anyone into, the physical answer is the Vigil Hall — a modest, unglamorous building near the local shrine or almonry, kept by lay vigil-keepers (traditionally widowed or elderly, traditionally paid almost nothing, traditionally among the best-informed people in town about who just died owing what to whom). Every major town has one. It is exactly the kind of small, load-bearing institution that can hold a scene, a rumor, or a body the party very badly needs to examine, without a word of this needing to touch the Undercourt, the binding site, or anything else still sealed for later.

THE ASPECTS AND THE CANON OF SAINTS

The Matron is one. This is the first thing a Zhuvedian child learns and the last thing a Zhuvedian heretic denies, and the empire has argued about almost everything else instead. What the faith does have — what any faith serving a whole civilization eventually acquires — is a vocabulary for the different things one goddess does, and a long roll of people she is held to have done them through.

THE DOCTRINE OF ASPECTS

An Aspect is an office the Matron holds, not a part she is divided into. The distinction sounds like hairsplitting and is in fact the sharpest doctrinal line in the empire, because two centuries of schism have taught the Church exactly how a metaphor becomes a second god. Orthodoxy is carried by a preposition: one says the Matron in her Hunt, never the Matron of the Hunt as though there were another Matron elsewhere doing something else. The heresy of Division — teaching the Aspects as distinct powers — was condemned four hundred years ago and is still the charge the Sanctum reaches for first, which tells you how often somebody drifts into it by accident on a cold night in a country parish.

For a cleric, the Aspect is the shape of the calling rather than its source. The power is the Matron's; the Aspect is which of her offices the caller was answered from, and it determines the colour of the vestment, the wording of the daily office, and which shrine will feed you when you arrive wet and unannounced. Sanction is issued against an Aspect: a warrant-medal is stamped on its reverse with the Aspect's mark, and a Watch cleric ministering as a Hunt cleric is committing a paperwork offence, not a sin.

THE SEVEN RECOGNIZED ASPECTS

Seven Aspects hold formal recognition from the Matriarchate. The correspondence to a cleric's domain is exact and unremarkable to anyone in the world; the table below is for the table, not for the fiction.

Aspect	Domain	Who Serves It, and How She Is Shown
The Watch at the Threshold	Life	Vigil-keepers, hospitallers, almonry clergy, midwives — the commonest calling in the empire by a wide margin. Shown as a wolf lying across a doorway, a lamp behind it.
The Long Hunt	War	Legion chaplains, the Church militant, Censor-Captains, anyone whose duty is endurance rather than fury. Shown as a wolf at a steady trot, never at a sprint.
The Long Memory	Knowledge	Archivists, jurists, the Chartered Scriptorium, and — to the irritation of everyone else — the Office of Omens. Shown as a wolf with its head turned back over its shoulder.

Aspect	Domain	Who Serves It, and How She Is Shown
The Lamp Left Burning	Light	Vigil-hall lamplighters, lighthouse and channel-light keepers, the night offices. Shown as a lit lamp, and an eye reflecting it.
The Elder Range	Nature	The Old Observance, field-shrine keepers, druids and rangers who never asked anyone's permission. Shown with no icon at all: a bare stone, a marked tree.
The Winter Voice	Tempest	The northern liturgies, storm-country parishes, Orlath, and the Ardden monastery-burghs. Shown as an open throat, the howl drawn as visible breath.
The Limping Bitch	Trickery	Nobody, officially. Everybody, in the provinces. Shown as a she-wolf dragging a hind leg.

The Limping Bitch. The seventh is the one worth a paragraph. She is the she-wolf who feigns a broken leg to draw the hunter away from the den — deception spent entirely in defence of what is behind her. She has never been formally recognized and has never once been suppressed. She is not painted in a single cathedral in the Crownlands and she is painted on roughly half the barn doors in the Suthmark. Ask a Prelate about her and you will get a careful sentence about folk piety; ask a village woman and she will tell you which of her neighbours the Matron limped for. A Trickery cleric in this empire is entirely real, entirely unlicensed, and entirely unsurprising to anyone outside the Sanctum.

DM Only: the Limping Bitch is the closest the orthodox faith comes to admitting that a lie told to protect the den is not the same crime as an oath broken for advantage. That distinction is the campaign's whole moral engine, sitting in plain sight on a barn door, and no theologian in the empire has connected it to the Founding. If a player character ever draws the line out loud in front of clergy, the room should go very quiet.

THE ASPECTS THE CANON DOES NOT HAVE

Tables that use domains beyond the 2014 Player's Handbook will find the empire has opinions, and the gaps are as informative as the entries.

Domain	Standing in the Empire
Grave	The Watch in its darker register — the Threshold-Wardens, who deal with what the Vigil exists to prevent when the Vigil has already failed. Recognized, small, and nobody's first choice of dinner guest.
Forge	The Teeth of the Mountain: the Stonesworn's Aspect, recognized fully in Tarnovar and not at all in the Crownlands, since recognizing it would concede that Tarnovar's clergy are clergy.

Domain	Standing in the Empire
Order	The Packlaw itself, venerated as an office rather than a doctrine. Favored by magistrates, and by exactly the sort of person who becomes one.
Nature	See The Elder Range — the Old Observance's Aspect. The Church's position remains studied non-comment, for reasons the DM understands better than the Synod does.
Death	There is no Aspect, and the absence is deliberate doctrine rather than an oversight. Divine power answering to death in this empire is not answering from the Matron, and the Office of Omens keeps a file classification open against the day someone proves it.
Arcana	No Aspect, and a jurisdictional war waiting to happen. Thaumaturgy is chartered, not blessed; a cleric of Arcana would set the Charter and the Sanction arguing for a decade over which of them had been insulted.

DM Only: a player who brings a Death cleric to this table is not doing something the setting forbids. They are doing something the setting has been waiting for. The honest answer to who answers that call is open, and the thing beneath the Old Forum is at least as plausible a candidate as anything the Sanctum has filed. Do not decide it early, and do not tell them there is a question.

OATHS AND THE PALADIN

In a world where a sworn word has literal weight, a paladin is not a knight with spells. A paladin is a person carrying a binding heavy enough to be felt, and the empire treats them accordingly: with respect, with wariness, and with paperwork.

Devotion: the Crown-sworn and the Church's own Oathwards. The most institutionally comfortable of the oaths and the most closely watched, because a Devotion paladin who concludes his institution is the thing in breach becomes the empire's least manageable problem. Emperor Qilvayas is Crown-sworn.

The Ancients: the Green Watch — the Old Observance's paladins, sworn at field-shrines and standing stones rather than altars, holding warrants nobody issued. Tolerated warmly in the provinces, received in the Sanctum the way a magistrate receives a folk remedy.

Vengeance: the Wolf-Price made a vocation. Recognized in the provinces, where blood debt is a functioning legal category, and quietly deplored at court, where it is an embarrassment with a sword. Ban Dregan Morn is what this oath looks like when nobody supervises it for thirty years.

DM Only — the Oathbreaker: the DMG's Oathbreaker is not a subclass in this setting so much as a diagnosis. A paladin who breaks his oath and keeps the power is walking, step for step, the road the Founder walked, and this world's metaphysics say that road leads somewhere specific and occupied. If a player goes there, the shadow beneath Aenodira notices immediately, and what it offers will be generous. This is a campaign-altering event and should be played as one, not as a mechanical swap.

THE CANON OF SAINTS

Canonization in the Zhuvedian Church requires three things: a documented life, a testified act, and the passage of a full generation, so that nobody is made a saint by the people who liked them. The Synod of the Grey rules; the Matriarch confirms; the parishes, in practice, decide first and let the paperwork catch up. Fourteen names carry the whole empire's devotion, and the roll below is what a literate Zhuvedian would be able to recite badly and a village priest perfectly.

Feast	Saint, and What They Are For
Wolfmoon 1	Lupenna of the First Shrine — hospitality, guest-right, roadside shrines
Wolfmoon 4	Ivessa of the Ford — rearguards, ferrymen, and anyone who says go on without me
Thawtide 11	Coren the Unhurried — vigil-keepers, night-workers, and the patient
Sowmonth 8	Yenna Corvane — advocates and the badly represented
Sowmonth 27	Perisse the Milkless — foundlings, nurses, and the bound-freed
Haymonth 9	Vosk the Field-Cutter — surgeons, medics, and their consciences
Harvestide 2	Bellara of Ambervale — harvests, almoners, and honest thieves
Vinmoon 3	Ilvane the Sea-Kept — pilots, harbor-hands, and merchants who honor a bad contract
Fallowmonth 21	Halvard of the Quiet Rite — stonewrights, record-keepers, unglamorous fidelity
Greywane 14	Tobrin Ashfall — the falsely accused
Greywane 30	Elleth of the Grey Gate — gatekeepers, quarantine wardens, the unforgivable choice
Longdark 19	Odarr of the Nine Winters — winter travelers, the maimed, the stubborn
Threshold 6	Marek the Witness — witnesses, oath-keepers, inconvenient truth
struck	Ovric, Struck from the Canon — nothing, officially

THE LIVES

Lupenna of the First Shrine. The woman at whose roadside fire the Matron was first fed by a Zhuvedian hand. Her feast opens the year. Shown as a bowl set outside a door.

Ivessa of the Ford. Held a river crossing through one night so a village could get behind her. Found at dawn still upright, dead, spear planted in the gravel. Three separate towns claim the ford, and the Church has never adjudicated, because settling it would require ruling on which river she died in.

Coren the Unhurried. Kept four thousand nights' Vigil and refused ordination six times. Shown as a short wick over a very large reservoir of oil. Canonized over the objection of the Sanctum, which found his refusals insubordinate; the parishes did it anyway and the Matriarchate ratified a fait accompli.

Yenna Corvane. A jurist who argued four hundred wolf-price cases for the poor and lost most of them deliberately, on the record, to build the precedent that would win the four hundred and first. Archjurist Vhal keeps a copy of her losses; it is the most annotated book in the Law Commission.

Perisse the Milkless. Kept nine orphans alive through a siege, three of them not her people. Shown as nine cups, one of them cracked. Her cult is strongest among the fourth-tier bound, which is why the Church's enthusiasm for it is carefully measured.

Vosk the Field-Cutter. A legion surgeon who refused to sort the wounded by rank and was broken for it twice. Shown as a bone-saw and a coin, the coin being refused. The tiered-care system Book Three establishes is precisely what he refused to do, and the legions' surgeons keep his icon anyway, which is either irony or protest.

Bellara of Ambervale. Fed a famine district by miracle, or by emptying a duke's granary; the accounts differ and the Suthmark does not care which. Shown as an overturned grain measure.

Ilvane the Sea-Kept. Drowned getting a rival's crew off a wreck she had every commercial reason to leave. Shown as a rope in an open hand, untied. The Compact keeps her feast as a trading holiday and almost nobody goes to the shrine.

Halvard of the Quiet Rite. A Stonesworn dwarf who recut an entire oath-stone field alone over eleven years after a landslide, so that no family's oath would go unmarked. Shown as a chisel worn to a stub. Tarnovar keeps him; the Crownlands has never canonized him, because canonizing a Tarnovari saint would concede something.

Tobrin Ashfall. A hedge-priest who talked a town out of burning a girl for lycanthropy, then spent forty years proving he had been right. Shown as an unlit pyre, and still the least-preached saint in the Crownlands.

Elleth of the Grey Gate. Kept Aenodira's plague gate and decided who came in. Shown as a gate half shut. What she is actually venerated for is the ones she turned away.

Odarr of the Nine Winters. Kept the northern passes open for pilgrims through nine hard winters, lost both feet to the sixth, and did the last three on a sledge. Shown as a sledge and two empty boots. Orlath claims him hardest.

Marek the Witness. Saw a lord break a parley-oath, was invited to say he had seen nothing, and said what he saw. Executed for it. Shown as an open eye above a closed mouth.

Ovric, Struck from the Canon. Venerated for two centuries; removed by decree of the Synod ninety years ago, for reasons the decree does not state. The Ostmark parishes never stopped. Shown as the blank where an icon was.

THREE SAINTS WORTH MORE THAN A ROW

Marek the Witness is the saint of this campaign's central mechanism, and nobody in the empire has noticed. His feast falls in Threshold, the liminal month when old oaths are renewed and old debts settled, which is either an accident of the calendar or the only piece of liturgical honesty the Church has ever committed by mistake. His icon shows the mouth closed because he said the thing once and never repeated it. Parties who ask a priest why a witness-saint is depicted silent will get the standard answer — that testimony

given once truly needs no second telling — and it is the wrong answer, and the right one is not written down anywhere.

Lupenna is the saint of hospitality, and the empire's two worst crimes in living memory are both violations of guest-right: the Vintage Night, where congregations were killed under a festival's welcome, and the murder that made Olvesa a Saint-Regent, where a lord was killed under his host's roof. The Church has never preached the connection. The See of Orlath preaches almost nothing else.

DM Only — Ovric: he was struck because a Sanctum archivist working the deep stacks found what Ovric had actually witnessed and written down, and the Synod of the day chose the smaller scandal. The suppression decree is a masterpiece of saying nothing at four hundred words. The original file exists; it is in the Imperial Archive's closed levels, and it is the sort of thing a company holding the Lector's Seal could conceivably reach. What he witnessed touches the Founding. Do not spend this early, and do not make it the only route to the truth — it is a corroborating door, not the first one.

RELICS, FEASTS, AND THE PILGRIM ROADS

Every saint on the roll has relics, and the relic economy already described in this book runs on them: certified fragments with provenance documents, uncertified fragments with better stories, and the Second Treasury at Orlath holding a rival set the Sanctum considers fraudulent and cannot inspect. A saint's feast is a working holiday in the parishes that keep it — markets, processions, a suspension of certain kinds of legal proceeding — and a scheduling problem for everyone else. Four pilgrim roads carry real traffic:

The Matron's Road: Aenodira to Lupenna, two days on foot, walked by tens of thousands a year and lined the whole way with candle-stalls, relic-hawkers, and the most competitive begging in the empire.

The Penitent's Stair: the switchback ascent to the Reconciliation Shrine above Orlath. Crutches are left at the top; the town at the bottom sells them.

The Nine Winters Way: Odarr's passes, walked in winter on purpose. The ArIVEN monastery-burghs maintain the stations, which is diplomacy dressed as piety and works as both.

The Three Fords: three towns claim Ivessa's crossing and the Church has never adjudicated, because settling it would require ruling on which river she died in. Serious pilgrims walk all three and let the Matron sort it out.

STANDING: WHAT THE EMPIRE REMEMBERS

An institution is a memory with a building around it. In a world where sworn words carry literal weight, a party's relationship with a faction is not a reputation score in any abstract sense — it is the accumulated residue of small promises made and kept in that institution's sight. The Church calls it good odor. The legions call it a name. The Concord calls it a line of credit and means all three of the others.

Standing is deliberately the lightest possible system: one number per faction, from zero to five, moved by the DM at

the end of a session. There are no new rules to learn and nothing to look up mid-scene.

Tier	Name	What It Means at the Table
0	Unknown	You are a face. Doors open at the ordinary price and no faster.
1	Noted	Someone in the building knows your name. Minor favors are possible; you will be asked for one back.
2	Trusted	Advantage on Charisma checks made against members of this faction who know of you. Small requests are granted without a decision being taken upstairs.
3	Relied Upon	The faction brings you work rather than waiting to be asked. You gain access to one thing the faction controls and outsiders do not — a room, a record, a person, a route.
4	Of the Body	You are treated as internal. Its enemies are now yours whether you chose them or not, and its rivals adjust their opinion of you downward by one tier without meeting you.
5	Named	The faction will spend something real on you — money, people, or its own standing — once, and will expect the same. This is a promise, and in this world a promise is a weight.

THE FACTIONS

Twelve bodies are worth tracking in the campaign's first arc. Each moves on its own logic, and the last column is the thing a DM most needs at hand: what this faction will actually do for a party at Relied Upon.

Each entry names what raises the number, what lowers it, and — the thing a DM most needs at hand — what the faction will actually do for a party at Relied Upon.

The Lupine Throne and the Court. Rises when you make the restoration look competent, and you do it where the court can see. Falls when you embarrass it, or when you succeed so loudly that you become a faction of your own. At tier 3: an audience without the Lord Chamberlain arranging it first, which is a thing perhaps forty people in the empire have.

The Church of the Lupine Matron. Rises when you honor the Vigil, protect clergy, or resolve a matter without the Church having to be seen to act. Falls when you minister unsanctioned, shelter a claimed visionary, or win an argument with a Prelate in public. At tier 3: parish hospitality anywhere in loyalist territory, and a sealed letter that ends most provincial difficulties.

The Office of Omens. Rises when you bring them a claim, answer their questions, and are useful. Falls when you are useful to Vaelindra instead. At tier 3: nothing good — see below. This faction is the exception.

The Imperial Academy. Rises when you bring back knowledge, students, or credit; publication counts. Falls when you bring back a scandal, or make the faculty look like the people who examined you. At tier 3: the deep stacks, a

laboratory, and a professor's signature on a requisition nobody will question.

The Law Commission. Rises when you produce evidence that survives contact with a hearing. Falls when you resolve things in ways that would not. At tier 3: Archjurist Vhal's ear, and a Writ she will sign on a day's notice.

The Imperial Legions. Rises when you stand where you said you would stand. Falls when you leave; once is enough. At tier 3: a century's worth of soldiers who will listen, and a quartermaster who will lose the paperwork on what you take.

The Capital Merchants' Concord. Rises when you make a route safer or a contract enforceable. Falls when you cost anyone money, including honestly. At tier 3: credit, a factor in every major town, and the second-best intelligence network in the empire.

The Inkhands of Rivergate. Rises when you pay, shut up, and do not bring the Watch back with you. Falls on any of those three, reversed. At tier 3: unlicensed work at trade prices, and a door out of the district at any hour.

Vaelindra's referral circle. Rises when you keep her confidence and keep your word. Falls when you spend her name for advantage. At tier 3: introduction to the others she has referred over fifty years, which is a stranger and more useful list than it sounds.

The See of Orlath. Rises when you treat the schism as a disagreement between the faithful. Falls when you treat it as the Sanctum does. At tier 3: safe passage in the north, and the Second Treasury's doors.

The Tarnovar envoy's circle. Rises when you keep an oath at cost, where a Tarnovari can see it. Falls when you break a small one, at no cost, where a Tarnovari can see it. At tier 3: a hearing at Kamenhold, which nobody from the empire has had in a century.

The Golds and the Greys. Rises when you are seen at the Long Course, on a side, in the wrong weather. Falls when you are seen on the other side. At tier 3: three thousand people in a stand who will chant your name, which is a weapon and should be handled as one.

THE OFFICE OF OMENS IS NOT LIKE THE OTHERS

Standing with the Office is the one score a party should be trying to keep low, and the table should never be told so directly. Every tier of it is real, functioning access — the Office is polite, efficient, and genuinely helpful to those it has a file on. What rises with the tier is not favor but attention, and attention from a body whose determinations end in files rather than answers is the campaign's quietest trap. At tier 3 the Office assigns a Censor to the party's affairs as a courtesy. At tier 5 it knows where they sleep, who referred them, and what they are afraid of, and it has written all three down.

DM Only: run Office standing openly and let the players see the number go up. Let it feel like progress. Prelate Odell will be warm, useful, and completely sincere, because he is: he believes the Office is the only thing standing between the empire and a hundred unlicensed prophets. The horror arrives the first time the party needs the Office not to know something and discovers how much it already does.

STANDING PULLS AGAINST STANDING

The empire is not one body and cannot be pleased at once. When a party gains a tier with any of these, the DM should ask whether the opposed body noticed.

Gaining Here	Costs You With	Because
The See of Orlath	The Church of the Lupine Matron	There is exactly one licensing authority for the divine, and both of them are certain which.
Vaelindra's circle	The Office of Omens	The Office's objection to her is professional, not theological, which makes it worse.
The Inkhands	The Law Commission	Vhal's whole project is that the law should reach Rivergate. The Inkhands are the argument that it does not.
The Tarnovar envoy's circle	The Lupine Throne and the Court	Never again the wolf's word is a proverb about the people currently paying you.
The Golds	The Greys	And the reverse, and there is no third option, and the stands are how the capital says things it cannot say in the Forum.
The Concord	The Legions	Book Six's requisition powers are, from a merchant's chair, legalized theft with a drum behind it.

Two pairings are deliberately not opposed, and the reason is worth a DM's attention. The Academy sits comfortably beside almost everything, which is what makes it the best cover in the empire and the reason a graduating cohort can move through every one of these rooms. And the Church and the Throne do not appear opposite each other anywhere on this table — not because they agree, but because neither can afford to make a party choose. The day one of them does is a campaign event.

MAGIC AND THE WORD

THE WEIGHT OF THE WORD

The setting's metaphysical signature, formalized: in the world of the Lupine Matron, sworn words have literal weight. An oath spoken with intent creates a real, thin binding — imperceptible to almost everyone, cumulative across a civilization, and the reason this world's history keeps rhyming. It is why the Tarnovari swear on stone (stone holds what air forgets), why Ban Dregan's Fence works on the level of dread as well as deterrence, why Duke Norr's tens of thousands of personal oaths constitute a strategic reality, why the Church treats vows as sacraments and the law treats perjury as blasphemy's cousin — and why the breaking of the first great covenant could birth a god-sized wound. Mechanically this changes nothing: no new rules, no new subsystems. It is the flavor layer that makes every class, spell, and social contract in 5e feel native to this world rather than imported into it.

DIVINE MAGIC AND THE SANCTION

Divine magic flows from the Matron — genuinely. Clerics, paladins, and divine casters channel her power exactly as the rules describe, and the power is real regardless of what any institution rules about it. What the Church of the Lupine Matron claims is not the source but the license: the Sanction, its asserted sole authority to ordain who may lawfully channel, interpret, or minister. A sanctioned cleric carries a pewter warrant-medal; an unsanctioned healer in Church lands is a theological problem that the Office of Omens exists, in large part, to solve. The See of Orlath issues its own rival sanction — which means the fractured empire has two licensing authorities for the same living goddess, and she has conspicuously declined to rule on the dispute: both churches' clerics keep their spells. The DM-facing joke is quiet and total: the Matron answers everyone who calls sincerely, and the institutions have built two empires of paperwork on top of her silence.

CHARTERED THAUMATURGY — THE ARCANES

The academy already treats magic as “a specialized skill like any other” (canon), and this pass extends that to the empire's whole arcane culture: wizardry is chartered, credentialed, and bureaucratized wonder — the Byzantine relationship to engineering, applied to the impossible. A Chartered Thaumaturge of the House of the Craft holds a license enumerating the schools they may practice and the wards they may raise; the Charter is prestige, employability, and legal cover in one document. Outside the charter system live the hedge-mages — village workers of small practical magic, tolerated exactly as long as nothing goes wrong — and Rivergate's gray market in unlicensed scrollwork, where the penalty structure has taught practitioners to be very good or very quick. Sorcerers (“the Kindled”) sit awkwardly across all categories: power without study reads to the chartered as cheating and to the Church as a question, and bloodline fire in a world of covenant-metaphysics invites the obvious whisper — whose old bargain are you carrying?

WARLOCKS: THE SWORN

A pact is an oath, and a warlock is a person who swore one to something that answered. In this setting that makes warlocks theologically radioactive in Church lands — not because their power is necessarily evil, but because an unexamined covenant is precisely the category of thing this world's buried history proves can end civilizations. The Office of Omens keeps a standing file classification for suspected pact-bearers. Velmareth, characteristically, keeps a fee schedule instead. (**DM note:** warlock patrons should be built carefully in this setting — every patron relationship is a live wire running near the campaign's central mechanism, and at least one patron option, developed later with sign-off, could knowingly or unknowingly trace back to the thing beneath Aenodira.)

THE OLD OBSERVANCE

Druids and rangers practice the faith's pre-imperial stratum — the Matron as she was worshipped before there was an empire to sanction anything: field-shrines, first-fruits, the wolf-watch on winter roads. The Suthmark's harvest processions and planting-calendar saints' days (canon) are the domesticated descendant of this; in Tarnovar's Old

Wood and the Ardven feels it survives undomesticated. The Church's position on the Old Observance is studied non-comment: it cannot condemn practices older than its own doctrine without inviting questions about what else predates doctrine — a nervousness the DM knows is better-founded than the Synod does.

SCARRED GROUND

Magic is scarred where great betrayals happened. Wards will not anchor at the Cold Door (canon); the same principle generalizes gently across the world: sites of oath-breaking at scale — massacre-fields under parley signs, the Weld, the deeps beneath the Old Forum — resist beneficial magic, sour divination, and hold cold. Practitioners call such places thin-written. No mechanical subsystem: adjudicate as environmental flavor with occasional concrete effects (disadvantage on a ritual here, a divination returning grief instead of answers there), always as story.

THE SHE-WOLF OF THE NIGHT SKY

The Matron's iconography is lunar and nocturnal: the She-Wolf of the Night Sky, the moon her watching eye, the stars her pack, dawn her gift rather than her element. The coronation prayer's address to the night sky is theologically precise, not poetic — the great liturgies are sung at night, and the Drow are her first-favored children of the dark. Dawn services exist and are beloved, but every Zhuvedian knows in their bones which direction prayer faces after sundown: up.

THE PACKLAW: GENDER AND AUTHORITY

A pattern runs through the empire's seats of settled power that Zhuvedian doctrine names outright rather than leaving unremarked: Empress Nyreeza ruled in her own right, not as regent; Duchess Vasq, Voivode Morn, Matriarch Corvane, Saint-Regent Olvesa, Legate Thorne, and Mistress Shen hold their offices by the same unquestioned legitimacy a man would. The Church calls this the Packlaw — teaching that the Matron leads Her pack as the wisest wolf leads hers, by right of endurance and judgment rather than raw strength, and that a pack's survival runs through its mothers as often as its sires. It bars no man from rule — Qilvayas sits the Lupine Throne — but it means nobody in the Crownlands remarks on a woman holding a duchy, a see, or an empire, any more than a person in our world remarks on a man holding one. The Imperial Cult's doctrine that the ruling bloodline carries Zhuvedus's divine spark sits easily beside it: the spark passes through blood, not sex.

The doctrine runs strongest wherever authority is settled — thrones, duchies, sees, the machinery of a functioning institution — because settled authority is what the pack already recognizes. Authority still being fought for skews male throughout the fractured territories not by any law but by the same logic in reverse: a bastard never legitimized, a king awaiting a coronation not yet held, a raider refused a title four times, a warden whose authority his own Voivode has never sanctioned. A pack does not hand its trust to what hasn't yet proven it belongs. Once claimed and settled, the Packlaw would apply to these powers precisely as it does to the Crownlands — a detail their courts have not yet had cause to consider.

THE WOLF-SHAPE: LYCANTHROPY AND DOCTRINE

In an empire whose goddess wears the wolf, lycanthropy cannot be neutral — and is not. Church doctrine holds the wolf-shape taken by curse to be profanation, the Matron's image stolen and worn wrongly, and the Church hunts it with grim formality (the wolf-trial is a recognized proceeding, with recognized abuses). Folk belief, older and quieter, holds that sometimes the shape is her mark — and that the difference is visible in what the changed one does under the moon. Between doctrine and folk belief runs the setting's built-in gothic engine: the falsely accused, the genuinely monstrous, and the rare, terrifying possibility of a true-marked one, about which the Church's files are sealed and the Old Observance says nothing at all, loudly.

MARRIAGE AS OATH, AND THE DENMOTHER'S CHOICE

A wedding vow is the single most common binding oath an ordinary Zhuvedian will ever speak, and it carries the same literal weight as any other. Marriage is sworn before a Church witness in the Crownlands and loyalist provinces, or at the standing stones in Tarnovar, consistent with Tarnovari oath-custom generally. An unrepaired infidelity or abandonment is not merely private sorrow — unhealed, it is a small, personal echo of Zhuvedus's own crime, whether or not either party has ever heard the founding myth. Divorce exists, and, consistent with how the empire treats broken oaths everywhere else, it is not a document but a counter-oath: a formal Release, requiring Church sanction and mutual consent, or, on proven grave breach, a magistrate or Church tribunal may grant it unilaterally. A marriage ended without Release carries the same taint as any other unrepaired vow; one ended properly carries none.

Titled succession follows the Packlaw's logic rather than strict primogeniture: a ruling parent formally names their heir by open declaration — the Denmother's Choice — revisable over the parent's lifetime, and it need not fall to the eldest, or even to a child by blood, in rare and dramatic cases. It is the naming that carries legal force, not the birth order. Duchess Vasq's court runs on this fact: with Aldous the elder, sickly, and Tavian the younger, ambitious, her succession is a live and unresolved question rather than a formality — which is precisely why the Garland needs to be as good as it is. Qilvayas himself has named no heir of either kind, a fact his court is certainly aware of and does not discuss above a whisper. Set against the Packlaw's confidence sits a quieter fact the court keeps quiet. For a line as long-lived as the Founder's Blood, its emperors have not lasted: within living memory the throne has turned over faster than a Drow reign should end, twice passing to heirs too young to rule and the regents who ruled for them. Each turn carries its own settled explanation — a fever, a faction, a border gone wrong — and each is plausible, and no one at court sets them side by side. Nyreeza, ruling in her own right to a son old enough to follow her without a regent, was the first steadiness the throne had known in generations; her disappearance ended it. That is the weight beneath the whisper that Qilvayas has named no heir. An heir is a small and mortal thing to hang an empire on, in a family that has not managed to keep its rulers.

Regional variation is light but real. Tarnovar extends its existing custom — a dead Tarnovari's oaths, not their body,

are what the living formally inherit, spoken at the standing stones by whoever takes up the unfinished promise — to leadership itself: a title passes to whoever takes up the stone, which is very often a named heir but does not have to be. The Suthmark times common inheritance to the harvest calendar, the same rhythm as its burials, so estates settle at a season's turn rather than the moment of death. Elsewhere, ordinary property is governed by local custom rather than fixed imperial law.

LANGUAGE AND LITERACY

Old Imperial and Common divide along a written and spoken line, not a regional one, and Old Imperial is now fully dead as anyone's native tongue — no community, however remote, still dreams in it. It survives purely by function, kept alive where the empire's oldest institutions still need it: the Golden Tablets and the Zhuvedian Laws as drafted, the Church's rites and the Office of Omens' formal writs, proceedings at Highcourt, and the Academy's core instruction. Common is what the empire actually speaks, in every province from the Crownlands to the Brekelands, and nobody is born to anything else.

Literacy in Old Imperial tracks education and office, not province or blood — which means it cuts across the empire sideways, in a way region never does. A Farrowgate dock laborer and an Ostmark legion sergeant are equally fluent in spoken Common and equally unable to read a magistrate's writ; what separates either of them from Archjurist Vhal is Academy admission, clerical training, or a guild apprenticeship that happened to include letters, not where either was born. The party — Academy finalists, fluent and literate by training across all three houses — moves through a mostly unlettered world almost without noticing the advantage, which is worth surfacing at the table in an NPC's deference rather than stating outright.

The regional texture follows naturally from what's already established. Ardven's subsidized literacy is not simple generosity — it is Karvel's argument made visible, that his restoration delivers what Aenodira's has only promised, and it only reads as an argument because the empire's own baseline is genuinely worse. Tarnovar inverts the hierarchy entirely: a culture that swears on standing stones treats the written word as the lesser evidence, not the greater, since a spoken oath is witnessed and binding the instant it leaves the mouth, while a written contract is what people resort to when they don't trust each other enough to swear properly. Book Two's innovation — that an oath binds at law only if sworn before a recognized witness — is something Tarnovar has practiced by custom for longer than the empire has had a Book to write it in, and a Tarnovari envoy who says as much to an excited Aenodiran clerk isn't being rude; she's stating a fact of her own upbringing.

The law pass sharpens the stakes considerably. Books One through Four run entirely on witness, mark, and register — which means the Laws' actual protection reaches only as far as a person's access to someone who can read and write on their behalf. An unwitnessed, unrecorded arrangement isn't illegal under Book One, only unenforceable, and the people least likely to find a recorded witness are, disproportionately, the people least able to read what they'd be agreeing to in the first place. It is the campaign's central mechanism in miniature: the silence around a broken word doesn't require malice, only a gap nobody thought to close. Rivergate's document underworld — Mosse's dead seals, the Inkhands' arrangements, a district that trades in provenance rather

than fabrication — isn't new invention against this backdrop. It's what a for-hire literacy economy looks like once someone thinks to name it.

How this framework maps onto the Marked is left deliberately open here, reserved for the dedicated personhood pass — Book One's own unresolved clause deserves its full weight, not a footnote borrowed from someone else's gap.

THE WILLING SHAPE: WILDSHAPE AND DOCTRINE

Wildshape is not lycanthropy, and Church doctrine — for once — agrees without much argument. A druid's wolf-shape is willed, self-possessed, and takes nothing from anyone; there is no theft of the Matron's image to punish, because nothing was stolen. The wolf-trial has no jurisdiction here, and no sanctioned Church court has ever convened one against a druid for the shape itself. Folk belief goes further and warmer than doctrine bothers to: in the provinces, and especially where the Old Observance still runs strong, a druid who wears the wolf is read as walking proof of favor, and villages that would never touch a stray wolf for luck will happily touch the hem of a druid who has just changed back.

The Office of Omens, characteristically, finds a third position: not persecution, but paperwork. A Chartered practitioner's licensing file quietly notes wildshape capability the way it notes any other unusual talent, and a druid who takes wolf-shape often or publicly enough to be noticed can expect a polite, entirely non-threatening visit from someone with a ledger, asking careful questions about frequency, circumstance, and whether anything unusual happens under the moon. Nothing comes of it, usually. The Office simply likes to know where the Matron's shape is currently walking around — and reserves the right to be very interested indeed if it ever hears the word "unusual" twice about the same person.

THE WOLF-PRICE: BLOOD DEBTS AND THE PROVINCES

A wolf's death by human hand carries two separate reckonings, and only one of them is the law's. Imperial statute — reformed under Qilvayas to say plainly what older law only implied — recognizes self-defense as a full defense against a wolf-killing charge, provided the killing is reported to a magistrate within three days and the body produced or accounted for. Get that right, in a place with a magistrate worth the name, and the law is satisfied.

The law was never the whole of it. Older than any statute is the Wolf-Price — a debt owed not to the throne but to the wolf itself, or to whatever stands in for it: the nearest shrine-keeper, the local almonry, sometimes an old woman in a village with no shrine at all who has simply always been the one people pay. The price is small and never negotiable — coin, meat, a season's labor, whatever the keeper judges fits the death — and paying it has nothing to do with guilt or innocence. A traveler who kills a wolf defending a child pays exactly the same price as one who kills carelessly; the debt isn't about fault, it's about balance. What changes with the circumstances is reputation: pay the price promptly and the story that follows out of town is "they did right by it." Delay, argue, or leave before the shrine-keeper is satisfied, and the story that follows is worse than anything a magistrate could write down — and in places far enough from a garrison, the

magistrate's paperwork was never going to be what protected you anyway.

THE CHOSEN BEAST: COMPANIONS AND THE BEFRIENDED

A wolf that chooses a person — a ranger's companion, a freed animal that stays, a pack that walks a traveler's road unbidden — is read across the empire as the Matron's visible favor, and it functions like minor rank: doors open, elders nod, clergy will bless the animal (and quietly take note of the person). Doctrine distinguishes sharply between the befriended and the tamed. A wolf that stays of its own will honors the Matron; a wolf collared, caged, leashed, or sold profanes her — a wolf-cage is scandal verging on sacrilege, and no honest market in the empire sells one. Feeding wild wolves is lawful and, at the empire's margins, encouraged (Orlath's pilgrim stations are the famous case); the custom everywhere else is superstitious care — you feed the pack at the treeline, and you never call them in.

Mechanically nothing changes — but the mapping matters: the Beast Master ranger is where core 5e grants a true permanent companion, and a Beast Master whose bond is a wolf is the standing, sacred-animal version of everything above — not a temporary shape but a lasting relationship with the Matron's own beast, which provincial villages read as being touched and capital institutions keep on file. Druids, by contrast, get no permanent companion in core rules; wildshape is the druid's entire animal relationship, and doctrine treats it accordingly (see *The Willing Shape*). Familiars and animal handling work as written. Socially, a visible wolf companion is standing — warmer reactions among the devout, harder scrutiny from the Office of Omens, exactly the wildshape grammar (a wolf-shaped familiar, being a spirit wearing her shape, is doctrinally fascinating and reliably file-worthy). **DM only, and quietly load-bearing:** wolves will not abide thin-written ground. A companion wolf is, functionally, a living Wardstone — it will balk at scarred places before any instrument reads them — and no befriended wolf, however loyal, will enter the Old Forum district. Its person will never know why. The DM will.

RELICS AND THE BLESSED ECONOMY (APPROVED FRAME)

Per the approved fork: arcane items are scarce and chartered, but relics and blessed items flow through the faith. The Church's almonies sell sanctioned mercy at honest prices — stamped healing potions brewed under the Sanction, holy water, blessed tapers — and the great relic-treasures hold the setting's serious magic: the femur of a saint inside a mace-head, a battle-standard that has never fallen, a reliquary that quiets fever in a room. Mechanically, relics are official magic items wearing provenance — a +1 mace is the Ferrule of Saint Oswenna, and the provenance is the point. The schism doubles everything: Orlath maintains a rival relic-treasure and disputes the authenticity of half the Sanctum's inventory, Rivergate runs a brisk trade in false relics (and, very occasionally, terrifyingly real ones with forged papers), and the Office of Omens polices the whole mess. Player-facing consequence: healing is purchasable and human-scaled; wonder is rare, holy, and always has a story attached.

CURRENCY: THE ZHUVEN

The empire's standard gold coin is the Zhuven — struck at Aenodira, Zhuvedus's profile on the obverse and the She-Wolf on the reverse, plural Zhuvens. It's the coin's formal name: what a magistrate enters in a ledger, what the Exchange's counting-houses call it, what appears in any written instrument. Almost nobody speaks it aloud. In Common, the coin is simply a wolf — “three wolves for a night's lodging,” “a wolf a day, all found” — slang so old and so universal that most speakers have long since stopped hearing the metal in it at all. It's a small, exact echo of the split described above (see *Language and Literacy*): the lettered name a thing by what's written on it, and everyone else names it by what they can plainly see.

Smaller denominations get considerably less ceremony: a silver strand and a copper mote, restruck by whichever provincial mint most recently had working dies, with no particular consistency of design or weight beyond what a scale will bear out. Table pricing stays the familiar gp/sp/cp abstraction throughout — the Zhuven, strand, and mote are simply what those coins are actually called and look like in hand.

Not every hand that takes a Zhuven cares what's stamped on it. Velmareth's counting-houses weigh gold rather than read it, and take a Zhuven exactly as readily as any other coin of the same fineness — characteristically mercantile indifference to whose face buys the bread. Duke Norr doesn't melt down the Zhuvens his conquests bring him; he restrikes them, his own seal punched directly over the wolf, which costs him nothing and says everything the rest of his administration already says by other means. In Tarnovar, a Zhuven spends the same as anywhere, but the old proverb holds it at arm's length regardless: “a stone remembers, a coin forgets” — coin is for strangers, and a given word is worth more than money between anyone who matters.

MEDICINE AND DISEASE

Healing in the empire runs on the same three-tier certification Book Three already governs, though nobody usually says it that way. Divine healing moves through the Church's Sanction — stamped potions, laying-on of hands, a warrant-medaled cleric at an almonry — expensive, guaranteed, and genuinely magical. Arcane healing sits under the Charter, scarcer and stranger, and mostly beside the point for an ordinary complaint. The third tier, mundane physic, falls to the Crown and its guilds the same as any other trade: Academy-trained physicians and chirurgeons, guild-certified, competent, and concentrated almost entirely in the cities and among people who can pay guild rates for years of someone's training. All three are real, licensed, and largely irrelevant to how most of the empire actually gets treated.

Below every certified tier — the overwhelming majority of care, delivered to the overwhelming majority of people — sits the same uncertified layer that already covers hedge-magic and the shrine-keeper's Wolf-Price: a herbwife, a bonesetter, a midwife, the person in a village who has simply always been the one people go to. None of it is illegal — nobody built a licensing apparatus for it any more than anyone licenses a mother setting a child's fever, and the guilds have never troubled to claim jurisdiction over care too poor to be worth regulating. It is also the only medicine most of the empire will ever see, which means its quality is a matter of local reputation and nothing else: genuinely skilled in one

village, genuinely useless in the next, and nobody keeping a register either way.

Farrowgate sharpens the whole picture into an actual crisis rather than an abstraction. The district's overcrowded, unplanned housing along the Long Wall's inner face breeds a chronic, recurring lung-sickness residents call the Damp — nothing exotic, nothing shadow-touched, just what happens when too many displaced people are packed into rooms with too little light and worse drainage, generation after generation of refugees arriving to find the last generation's problem still unsolved. A stamped Potion of Healing cures an active case as completely and instantly as it closes a sword-wound; Church magic doesn't discriminate by the dignity of the ailment. What it can't do is fix a drainage ditch, and no almonry has ever claimed jurisdiction over municipal works. The Damp isn't a medical failure — it's a reach problem, exactly like the Brekelands' unenforced law against chattel slavery: the empire's principles are sound, its presence doesn't extend to the people who need them, and that gap is where the real damage happens.

Elsewhere the causes vary more than the pattern does. Velmareth's reed-sea breeds its own recurring fever — the marsh-ague, blamed locally on bad air off the channels rather than the mosquitoes that actually carry it, though the Compact's physicians have begun to suspect otherwise and haven't yet found anyone with the authority to act on the suspicion. Rivergate, characteristically, trades in the gap between the two: patent tonics and miracle cure-alls sold under forged Sanction marks or invented guild credentials, Book Four's forgery statute notwithstanding, because a bad batch of physic gets a customer's own judgment blamed long before anyone thinks to blame the seller. Rivergate discounts everything including the truth, and medicine is no exception.

DM Only: keep the Damp, and disease generally, mundane by design — same ruling as Greywell. Not every hardship in a fractured empire is the shadow's doing, and a party that starts reading every fever as metaplot loses the thing that makes the real metaplot land when it finally shows up.

PEOPLES OF THE EMPIRE

The empire is human-majority — right for its Byzantine texture — with the other peoples distributed where history put them. Distribution below; regional detail in Part V.

The Founder's Blood (Drow): Zhuvedus was Drow — the Matron's chosen, first-favored child of her night — and the imperial dynasty is his surviving line. Threnvos was Drow as well (approved): twin champions of the same goddess, the same blood, one throne. There is no Underdark and no spider-cult in this world; Drow are simply the old blood of the founding, and they are nearly gone — a scattering of ancient noble houses claiming distant dynastic kinship, and the throne itself. The founder's people dwindling to a single family on a single chair is the campaign's decline theme in miniature. A Drow character outside the dynasty is therefore an enormous statement (Session Zero's existing note, now with teeth): they will be read as dynastic kin, dynastic claimant, or something nobody has words for. **DELIBERATELY OPEN:** whether any line of Threnvos survives. If it does, it is Drow, it is rightful-claimant material of the highest order, and it should not be spent early — same handling class as the Tarnovar revelation.

Humans: The overwhelming majority everywhere, in named regional cultures: Zhuvedians (Crownlords core),

Ostfolk, Suthfolk, Tarnovari, Brekelanders, Velmarenes, Orlathines, Ardvenners, the Skell, Normerines. Human cultural texture per region in Part V.

Dwarves: The Stonesworn of Tarnovar's highlands — the stone-oath culture and dwarven nature are a natural marriage, and roughly a third of Tarnovar is dwarven, fully Tarnovari in identity. Smaller populations: the Suthmark's eastern hills (including the villages around Greywell, which is part of why the missing girls stay missing — hill-dwarf families have learned the valley's law does not climb), Normere's hired stonewrights, and the capital's masons' guild. Archivist Vell is a hill dwarf (which quietly explains a career that has outlasted four chancellors).

Elves: Wood elves keep to the deep forests — Tarnovar's Old Wood and the Ardven wilds — as the long-remembered folk of the Old Observance; canon-safe on the founding secret (2,000 years exceeds any living memory), but elven ballad-memory reaches closer to the fracture than human record does, which makes old elves valuable and dangerous listeners. High elf blood persists in a handful of faded Crownlords houses — more portraits than people now. Half-elves are the empire's courtier class (Chancellor Sorral, canon) and Velmareth's natural children.

Half-Orcs: Legion stock — respected veteran families of the Ostmark marches, descendants of frontier auxiliaries who earned the rolls the hard way. Brune Halloc of the Inkhands is one of Rivergate's. No orc 'menace' exists in this setting; the marches' old auxiliary peoples were absorbed, not fought.

Halflings: The river-trade people — Coppergate's copyists and landlords, the Ostrun barge families, Velmareth's middle guilds. Comfortable, networked, and collectively the best-informed civilians in the empire.

Gnomes: The House of the Craft's natural constituency — instrument-makers, ward-wrights, archival engineers. Tirell Mosse, dealer in defunct authorities, is a rock gnome (of course he is).

Tieflings — the Marked: In a world of covenant-metaphysics, tieflings are what an ancestor's bad bargain looks like three generations later: bloodlines carrying a covenant made flesh. Feared in Church lands, filed by the Office, tolerated in Velmareth and Rivergate where everything is tolerated at the right rate. A Marked character's line-covenant is a ready-made personal hook — and, handled with sign-off, one such line could eventually trace somewhere campaign-relevant.

Dragonborn — the Sarkanni: Rare famous foreigners: mercenary companies from across the southern sea, known by reputation (superb, expensive, contract-scrupulous — a Sarkanni company has never broken terms in living memory, which in THIS setting is remarkable and remarked upon). Available for PCs; minimal footprint otherwise.

The Wolves: Sacred empire-wide. Killing a wolf is terrible luck, worse law, and — in the provinces — grounds for the kind of trouble that magistrates decline to interrupt. Wolves are omen-bearers: their behavior is read the way other cultures read birds. (The DM knows the wolves of Aenodira have been leaving the Old Forum district, one family at a time, for three years.)

THE FOUNDING MYTH: ZHUVEDUS AND THE BROKEN OATH

THREE ACCOUNTS OF THE FOUNDER

No single account of Zhuvedus's nature is universally accepted. Three distinct traditions coexist, each serving different interests, and each believing itself the truth.

Church Doctrine (Public): The Church of the Lupine Matron teaches that Zhuvedus was a mortal hero, chosen and favored by the Matron but never divine himself — virtuous in his triumphs, flawed in his failures, and mortal in his death. To the Church, only the Matron is properly divine; elevating any mortal, however great, to godhood would be heretical. “Sinful children of Zhuvedus” is meant in this light: heirs to a great but flawed man, not to a god.

The Imperial Cult (Public): A smaller, older priesthood tied to the imperial household teaches otherwise — that Zhuvedus was elevated to divine or semi-divine status upon his death, and that the ruling bloodline carries a literal spark of his apotheosis. This doctrine underwrites the throne's claim to hereditary legitimacy: only Zhuvedus's line, in this telling, has the right to rule. The Church tolerates this cult's existence because confronting it directly would mean confronting the throne itself.

The Buried Truth (Hidden): A far older, deliberately suppressed tradition holds a darker and more specific account — that Zhuvedus was not the Matron's only champion in his own era, that his rise involved the destruction of a rival she had also favored, and that his triumph came at the cost of a sacred oath broken in her own witness. This is the account developed below. It survives only in fragments: old ballads the Church has worked for generations to lose, half-remembered oral traditions in the further provinces, and the private knowledge of a very few people still living — among them, Vaelindra.

THRENVOS AND THE SWORN COVENANT

Long before the empire existed in anything like its current form, the Matron favored more than one champion in a single generation. Alongside Zhuvedus stood Threnvos, leader of a different people with an equal claim to her blessing. Rather than see one destroy the other, she is said to have bound them under a sworn covenant — witnessed and sanctified by her own power — some form of joint rule, mutual restraint, or shared founding. The exact terms are lost. What survives is only that it was sacred, that both men swore it freely, and that it was meant to hold.

Zhuvedus broke it. He destroyed Threnvos and claimed sole right to found what became the empire, and he did it under the eyes of the god who had sanctified the promise between them.

THE OATHBREAKER'S CROWN

Zhuvedus was, by the account preserved in the buried tradition, a paladin — sworn to the Oath of Devotion, a champion whose given word was meant to be inviolable.

Breaking a sacred oath sworn before a god does not simply end quietly; it corrupts. In shattering his covenant with Threnvos, Zhuvedus fell from his oath and rose again as something else — an Oathbreaker, drawing on darker power in the same moment he used it to destroy his rival and seize the founding of the empire alone.

This is, perhaps, the empire's deepest and most carefully guarded irony: the throne whose current occupant is rewriting the Golden Tablets in pursuit of lawful restoration was founded by a broken oath, and the man who broke it drew the very power of his triumph from that betrayal. Neither the Church nor the imperial cult preserves this detail — both have every reason not to. A paladin or cleric with sufficient insight standing in the right place, however, might still recognize the particular wrongness of Oathbreaker corruption for what it is.

THE SHADOW'S ORIGIN (DM ONLY)

Threnvos did not simply die. Whatever he felt in that final moment — betrayal, rage, the specific grief of being killed by a man he'd trusted enough to swear brotherhood with — did not dissipate with him. It became the seed around which the wound left by the broken oath took shape. What waits in the vision's storm clouds is not a two-thousand-year-old grudge, and it is not a mindless force of pure entropy — it is both, fused together at the moment of its birth. The personal grievance gave the impersonal hunger a shape and a direction; the impersonal hunger has kept the personal grievance fed and growing long after any ordinary vengeful spirit would have faded.

That fusion is what makes the entity dangerous in the present tense. Every oath broken since — every noble house that abandoned fealty, every treaty a warlord tore up, every governor who quietly stopped honoring the crown — has fed something that already had a will and a memory attached to it. It has been growing more itself, not just larger, for two centuries of imperial fracture. This gives player and NPC choices around loyalty, betrayal, and broken promises a direct, if invisible, bearing on the threat shown in the opening vision — a mechanism the DM can use quietly throughout the campaign without ever stating it outright to the players.

The binding site — where the oath was broken and Threnvos died — lies beneath the imperial capital itself, beneath the Old Forum (confirmed; see Geography and Locations), which explains why the vision shows that specific city burning rather than some other place of significance. This ties the site's development directly to the capital's geography (see Geography and Locations) and gives Empress Nyreeza's disappearance a concrete shape: she was very likely searching for evidence of this true founding account, and quite possibly found the site itself.

THE TURNING AWAY (DM ONLY)

The founding was witnessed. Several hundred people stood in the Witness Hall beneath what is now the Old Forum to see Zhuvedus and Threnvos swear the covenant that would make an empire — and when Zhuvedus broke it, the assembly turned away in unison. In this world's metaphysics that is not cowardice but mechanism: oaths bind because they are witnessed, which is why the Tarnovari swear on stone before their kin, why marriage requires a Church witness, and why Duke Norr has every landholder swear before the assembled hall. When the assembly refused to see, they unwitnessed the covenant, and the unbinding is

what made the betrayal possible rather than merely unpunished. Zhuvedus struck the blow. The witnesses made it a founding.

Two consequences follow, and they govern the campaign. First, the shadow does not feed only on broken oaths but on the silence around them — every institutional look-away in the empire is the same act as the Hall, from a duchess letting a false record stand to a chancellor who asks exactly one question and never a second. Second, witnessing starves it, and the Vigil is the counter-rite: watched, lit, never left alone, owed to the dead as dead and not as the good. The Vigil is penance. It was instituted by the witnesses or their children as an apology none of their descendants remember making, which is why it is the one practice that survives unchanged across every schism in the empire.

The Golden Tablets were composed by the witnesses. The empire's sacred founding law is the self-exoneration document of the people who looked away — which is precisely what Empress Nyreeza meant when she wrote that the wound predates the Wall and the Tablets were written over it. The law was the cover-up, written first. Emperor Qilvayas is rewriting the Tablets now, and a legal code that makes oaths enforceable, witnessed, and recorded is, in this metaphysics, a starvation regimen against the thing beneath his city. He has built the only real weapon by institutional instinct, without any idea what he is doing. His Daily Draw — the habit his clerks find inefficient — is the Emperor personally witnessing one citizen a day, and it is the most important thing he does.

THE SCOURING, AND EMPEROR VASKAREN (DM ONLY)

Roughly two hundred years ago, as the fracture began, Emperor Vaskaren the Restorer went looking for why his empire was failing. He found the Witness Hall, and he had it erased — methodically, professionally, by masons working for weeks under a commission paid from the imperial purse with its purpose left blank. The second crime is the same crime: an act of un-witnessing performed by the one family the founding had made. Vaskaren's restoration failed. Qilvayas is the second restorer of that line, and does not know whether he is repeating the pattern or breaking it.

DM Only — The Throne's Short Reigns: The court's mundane explanations for the turnover are sincere, and may be the whole of it — a declining empire is hard on the families that rule it, and long-lived lines die of ordinary causes like any other. Whether a longer pattern runs beneath the ordinary ones is left deliberately open, the way the Matron's presence is: do not resolve it at the table, and do not hand a later DM the answer here. It is enough that Zhuvedus's line broke the covenant, buried the evidence, and scoured it a second time under Vaskaren — and that the family which did those things has never since held its throne in peace. Whether that is guilt, coincidence, or appetite is a door the campaign keeps ajar. If it is ever opened, it is opened at the table, by the players, and not before.

The scourers missed one section, forty feet up on the eastern gallery's highest tier, where a man on a scaffold worked alone at the end of a long day. Two spans of frieze survive: dozens of faces carved with the particularity of portraiture, house-sigils worked into collars, every one of them turned away in the same instant with the composure of people who have decided together and without a word to see nothing. Several of those houses hold seats at court

today. Vaskaren's order survives in the dynastic archive; it is how Nyreeza found the way down, and it is what waits, unopened, in her sealed dispatch case.

THE UNKEPT VIGIL (DM ONLY)

Threnvos was killed by his sworn brother under the Matron's own witness and buried under a wall, under a forum, under a founding myth — with no Vigil, no watching, no light, and nobody to see him home. The wound beneath Aenodira is an unkept vigil two thousand years long. The entity has two fused components: Threnvos's grief, which is a person and can be laid to rest, and the impersonal hunger the broken covenant unleashed, which is neither. Keeping the Vigil separates them — a real victory and not the victory. The grief goes quiet because it was the only part a funeral could touch; what remains does not grieve, does not remember, and cannot be reasoned with, because the part that could have been reasoned with is the part laid to rest.

This is the campaign's pivot from a dungeon problem to a civilization problem. What remains is fed by every broken word and every averted eye in the fractured empire, and it will keep eating as long as that continues. There is no monster to kill at the bottom of the hole. There is a civilization to fix — which makes the Zhuvedian Laws the actual weapon and the Grey-Gold Rising considerably more than a set piece. On the Matron: she may be down there, and may always have been, keeping the vigil nobody else would. Divine magic functions normally in the deep reach and clerics who pray receive, but there is never a form, never a voice, and never a confirmation. The ambiguity is permanent and deliberate.

EMPEROR QILVAYAS AND THE LUPINE THRONE

THE YOUNG EMPEROR

Qilvayas is a 110-year-old Drow — young by the standards of his long-lived race, but old enough to rule without a regent. He ascended to the Lupine Throne following the mysterious disappearance of his mother, Empress Nyreeza. Raised within the imperial palace, he received the finest education available in history, law, military strategy, theology, and statecraft. More importantly, he studied the empire's decline intimately, tracing its causes and contemplating solutions.

His youth gives him energy and idealism, but also makes him somewhat untested. He has never commanded armies in the field, never navigated the brutal realities of imperial politics at the highest level, and never faced the compromises that restoring an empire might demand. His vision is clear, his ambition genuine, and his belief in the righteousness of his cause unshakeable — but the question remains whether he can adapt that vision to reality without losing himself in the process.

THE MAN BEHIND THE CROWN

In person, Qilvayas is precise, courteous, and quietly relentless. He speaks softly and in the cadences of law — clauses, provisos, careful definitions — and he never raises his voice, having learned early that an emperor who shouts

has already lost the room. He works brutal hours, sleeps little even by Drow standards, and keeps three habits his court has learned to read: he walks the Long Course alone at dawn twice a week (guarded at a distance, to the Palatine Guard's despair); he answers petitions from commoners personally, one each day, chosen at random from the pile (his clerks call it the Daily Draw and privately think it inefficient; he considers it the point); and he has never, in three years, entered his mother's study. It is cleaned weekly, by his order. Nothing in it may be moved.

His grief for his mother is real, unresolved, and armored over with work. Known to almost no one: among Nyreeza's effects is a sealed dispatch case, her personal cipher on the lock, which Qilvayas has never opened — officially because the succession inventory has not reached it, actually because he is afraid of what it contains. It sits in the sealed study. If the party ever earns his trust deeply enough, or forces the issue, the case is a campaign-scale revelation waiting in a locked room.

THE COURT

Lord Chamberlain Vareth Kessin: Gatekeeper of access (see Geography and Locations, Highcourt). Serves the office more than the man; served Nyreeza first, and his opinion of how the son compares to the mother is a thing he has never once expressed, which everyone finds more unnerving than any stated view.

Archjurist Senna Vhal: Head of the Law Commission drafting the Zhuvedian Laws — brilliant, exhausted, and the person who actually holds the pen on the empire's new foundation. She fights a running quiet battle with Kessin over access to the Emperor and a louder one with the provinces over every clause. If the restoration has a second-most-important person, it is her, and she knows exactly how expendable that makes her.

Legate Bruvasca Thorne: Commander of the Palatine Guard (see Geography and Locations, the Garrison) — and, by any honest reckoning, the finest field commander the throne possesses. Her name was made at the Ashline, where she broke a Skellvard raid with eight hundred men against five times that number; the soldiers' songs about it are the closest thing the modern legions have to a victory anyone remembers. That is precisely her problem. The court needs her, the legions love her, and the throne can never quite decide whether her loyalty is a fact or a fortune it has not yet had to spend. She has been given every duty except the one she was made for: an army large enough to actually reconquer something. Her husband Bram, a retired quartermaster who manages her correspondence and is widely underestimated, keeps a private ledger of every promise the court has made her and quietly amends it after every audience. See The Powers of the Fractured Empire for her expanded profile and threads.

Mistress Averil Shen: Keeper of what is formally the Bureau of Correspondence and functionally the throne's intelligence service — and Mistress by the precise style of a commoner who holds an imperial bureau in her own right, not by courtesy — small, underfunded, and run on Shen's personal network of clerks, couriers, and debts. She was Nyreeza's creature before she was Qilvayas's, and she is the only member of the court who conducted her own private inquiry into the Empress's disappearance. What she found, or failed to find, is hers to reveal.

Hierophant Malzeth Corr: Head of the imperial cult (see The Keepers of the Ascent). Present at court for every rite and most councils; influential in exact proportion to how much the throne needs its divinity that season.

THE VISION OF RESTORATION

Qilvayas's plan for imperial restoration rests on several pillars:

Legal Reform: He seeks to rewrite the Golden Tablets, creating a new comprehensive legal code — the “Zhuvedian Laws” — that will modernize governance, eliminate corruption, and provide a unifying framework for all imperial territories. In his own words, these laws will be “forged by the fires of justice and cast in molds of wisdom.” This echoes the historical Corpus Juris Civilis of Emperor Justinian — the belief that law itself can be a civilizing and unifying force.

Administrative Revival: He is rebuilding imperial institutions that have atrophied or disappeared. The Imperial Academy is a key part of this effort, training a new generation of loyal, competent administrators who understand his vision.

Diplomatic Reunification: Where possible, Qilvayas prefers to bring fractured territories back into the fold through negotiation, offering stability, legal protection, and the prestige of the empire in exchange for renewed loyalty.

Military Force When Necessary: While he prefers peaceful methods, Qilvayas is prepared to use force against those who threaten imperial stability or refuse reasonable terms. He understands that some warlords and breakaway states will never willingly submit.

The question the campaign will explore is whether these idealistic goals can survive contact with reality — and what Qilvayas might become in the pursuit of restoration.

That question has a mythic precedent he likely doesn't know he's repeating. The empire's own founder broke a sacred oath in pursuit of a goal he believed justified it, and became something else in the process (see The Founding Myth: Zhuvedus and the Broken Oath). Every pragmatic compromise Qilvayas makes in the name of restoration — every ally set aside, every promise expedient to break — walks the same road his ancestor walked to its end. Whether he ever recognizes the echo is one of the campaign's central open questions.

LAW, OATH, AND BOUND LABOR

A reforming Emperor modeling himself on the historical architect of the Corpus Juris Civilis inherits that architect's hardest question along with his ambition: what does the empire's law actually say about a person's claim on another person's labor? Zhuvedian law has a clean, old answer for the worst of it — chattel slavery is illegal and doctrinally blasphemous throughout the empire, and has been for centuries, on grounds that grow directly from the oath-magic itself: if a sworn word binds because the speaker's will is real, then owning a person outright, denying they possess a will capable of being bound, is theologically incoherent. The capacity to swear is the proof of personhood; the law does not entertain owning what can vow.

Beneath that clean line sit three legal categories the coming Zhuvedian Laws will have to reconcile with each

other. Oath-bound service — Duke Norr’s entire system in Normere — is fully legal: a subject swears personal service directly, and the oath is real and binding because it was freely spoken, regardless of how much pressure made ‘freely’ a technicality. Debt-bondage and indenture are legal, regulated, and time-limited — an ordinary remedy for debt or minor infraction, bounded by contract, ending when the contract says it ends. Hostage-diplomacy, the Academy’s own admission practice among them, is a wholly separate category and not bondage at all: a diplomatic guarantee between powers in which the hostage retains full legal personhood and is owed treatment as an honored, if constrained, guest — a standard high enough to explain the practice’s respectability and loose enough that individual cases can still go quietly wrong.

The empire’s actual crisis is not its law but its reach. Imperial statute forbids chattel slavery everywhere; imperial statute has not reached everywhere in two hundred years. In the Brekelands, where warlord companies are, in plain terms, little better than bandits with armies, that gap is where the law’s clean answer stops being an abstraction and starts being an atrocity nobody enforces against. It is, in the most literal sense available, exactly what Qilvayas’s restoration is for.

THE MYSTERY OF EMPRESS NYREEZA

Qilvayas’s mother, Empress Nyreeza, disappeared under circumstances that remain unclear. She was the one who began revitalizing the Imperial Academy and took the first steps toward institutional reform. Her sudden absence created a power vacuum that Qilvayas filled, but it also left questions: Was her disappearance natural, political, or something more sinister? Did she flee, was she taken, or is she dead? Does Qilvayas know more than he admits?

Her fate remains a thread that can be pulled as the campaign develops — potentially revealing allies, enemies, conspiracies, or truths about the empire itself. One known thread already exists: the Seeress Vaelindra of the Still Waters was among the last people to meet with the Empress before her disappearance, and she has never spoken of what passed between them (see Key NPCs and Factions).

The working theory (see The Founding Myth: Zhuvedus and the Broken Oath) is that she was searching for evidence of the empire’s true founding account, and quite possibly found the site where it happened. Whether that discovery left her dead, transformed, or simply trapped somewhere no one has thought to look is still undecided, and can remain a genuine mystery the party uncovers through play.

THE ZHUVEDIAN LAWS

Archjurist Senna Vhal’s Law Commission is compiling the Zhuvedian Laws as seven Books, promulgated together this coming Solacre on the Long Course — the empire’s first comprehensive legal code since the Golden Tablets, and Qilvayas’s own described ambition: laws “forged by the fires of justice and cast in molds of wisdom.” Each Book governs one domain of imperial life; together they are meant to do for the fractured empire what the historical Corpus Juris Civilis did for Justinian’s.

THE GOLDEN TABLETS, IN FRAGMENT

The Tablets themselves do not survive complete — no document does, across two thousand years — but six lines are old enough and famous enough that every Seal-house student still has them by heart, carved over more than one provincial courthouse door:

“By the will of the Lupine Matron and the true voice of her chosen son, Zhuvedus, is this Empire raised, and these words set down that all who come after may know the order of things.”

“No free soul may be bound as chattel, for the wolf does not cage her cubs, and what can vow cannot be owned.”

“Let every vow be kept, for a broken word is a wound upon the pack.”

“He who spills wolf-blood without cause shall answer to the pack’s keeper, and the price shall be paid in full before the moon turns.”

“The Throne descends to whom the sitting wolf names before the pack, living or dying, and the pack shall know no other law of blood.”

“Set down in the year of the founding, by those who stood witness to the covenant of the Throne, that the memory of that day never fade.”

DM Only: read against the new Laws, what the fragments never do is the point. The vow-clause never says how anyone would know a vow was made, by whom, or that it was broken — no witness, no record, no venue; Book Two exists to close exactly that silence, and Qilvayas has no idea why closing it matters. The wolf-clause is the “older law only implied” self-defense the Wolf-Price statute already references (see The Wolf-Price, above) — now with actual words, and they still never say “self-defense,” because the Tablets never define what excuses a wolf’s death at all; they only set the price. And the colophon is the quiet one: the Tablets call their own authors “those who stood witness” — true, and the worst possible word for what the Witness Hall’s assembly actually did (see The Turning Away). Any Seal-house character who has known that line their whole life is, without realizing it, quoting the exact self-description of the people who un-witnessed a god’s covenant. Never explain this at the table. Let a player notice it, or don’t — either way it is already true the moment the frieze is found (Session Seven), and it lands harder for having been sitting in a courtroom inscription the whole campaign.

BOOK ONE — OF PERSONS

Book One codifies the empire’s existing framework for a person’s claim on another person’s labor (see Law, Oath, and Bound Labor, above), unchanged in substance: chattel slavery remains illegal and blasphemous; oath-bound service, debt-bondage and indenture, and hostage-diplomacy remain the three legal categories beneath it. Book One adds one new requirement: to be enforceable in an imperial court, an oath-bound service agreement or a debt-bondage indenture must be sworn before a witness empowered to record it — a Church witness, a magistrate, or, in Tarnovar, a standing stone. An unwitnessed labor arrangement is not illegal. It is simply not enforceable: a master with no recorded oath has no imperial recourse if the bound party walks away. It is, in a fractured empire whose worst abuses cluster exactly where no one is watching, a narrow but real answer — and it costs

the Commission nothing that wasn't already true of every other oath in Zhuvedian law.

The legal personhood of the Marked remains, deliberately, Book One's one unresolved clause. Velmareth already grants tieflings full legal standing that no other jurisdiction extends (see Free City of Velmareth and the Delta Compact) — whether the Commission ever writes that standing into imperial law is a live question the Laws do not yet answer.

The gap isn't that Zhuvedian law names the Marked as property — nothing does, and Book One's prohibition on chattel slavery is unconditional. The gap is that the law's actual protections depend on a Marked person's oath being recognized as an oath at all, and nothing in Book One or Book Two affirms that it is. A service agreement or an indenture is only as enforceable as its witness is willing to certify it, and a Church witness who privately doubts a tiefling's capacity to swear in the full theological sense can simply decline — leaving the exact same unwitnessed vulnerability the Laws were written to close, for exactly the people who can least afford it. The Office of Omens files the Marked the way it files a frequent wildshaper, except permanently rather than provisionally: a standing watch rather than a triggered one.

The doctrinal argument runs both ways, and runs sincerely both ways, which is why the Commission hasn't settled it. The exclusionary case borrows its caution directly from how the Church already treats warlocks: a pact is an oath that answered, and a bloodline visibly carrying an ancestor's answered bargain is a permanent, hereditary record of unfinished business with whatever wasn't the Matron. But the empire's own founding legal principle cuts the other way with equal force: if the capacity to swear is what proves personhood, a tiefling is the single most legally unambiguous case in the empire — proof carried on the body that an oath was sworn and something held. Vhal is understood to lean toward writing Velmareth's standard into Book One outright before promulgation; whether she has the votes, or the political room left this close to Solacre, is not yet decided even inside her own Commission.

DM Only: this is deliberately live, not deliberately open — unlike Nyreeza's fate or the throne's short reigns, this one is built to be decided, and decided by the party. Whatever they bring to bear before the Solacre promulgation — testimony, an alliance, evidence, a favor called in with Vhal or against her opposition — can tip Book One's final language either way. If the campaign reaches Solacre without the party engaging the question at all, the Commission settles it without them, off-screen, by whichever way the political weather was already blowing; the DM should not manufacture urgency the party hasn't created for itself.

BOOK TWO — OF OATHS AND THE WITNESS

Book Two states plainly what the empire's oldest customs have always assumed: a sworn word binds because it is witnessed. Marriage before a Church witness, Norr's personal oaths sworn before his assembled halls, the standing stones of Tarnovar — all already comply without a clause needing to change. What Book Two adds is procedural: perjury, a false oath sworn before a recognized witness, is a distinct offense from ordinary lying, tried in whatever venue the oath itself was sworn in. Its penalty is never a fine. It is entered against the liar's own signet-record (see Book Four) — a mark that follows the person rather than

a debt that can be paid off, which is precisely why Zhuvedian doctrine has always called perjury blasphemy's cousin rather than mere fraud.

BOOK THREE — OF THE SANCTION AND THE CHARTER

Book Three gives formal shape to certification across all three of the empire's licensing bodies — the Church's Sanction over divine goods and practice, the House of the Craft's Charter over arcane goods and practice, and the Crown and guilds over mundane trade, tolls, and weights and measures. In every domain, certification is two things, never one: a physical mark — a wax stamp, a pewter warrant-medal, a charter seal, a guild-stamp — and a matching written entry in the certifying body's own register: a parish or almonry ledger, a Chartered Scriptorium's roll, a guild's books. The mark alone proves nothing to a suspicious buyer or a sitting magistrate; what actually settles a dispute is whether the register entry exists and matches.

Possessing unstamped goods or practicing without a license is not, by itself, a crime — it shifts the burden. A magistrate, a Church tribunal, or a Charter inspector may demand the seller or practitioner produce their register entry on formal challenge, and it is the failure to produce one, not the missing stamp itself, that opens a case. This is the calculation Rivergate's gray market already prices into its discounts: the goods are usually genuine, and the risk being sold at a markdown is the registration, not the quality.

BOOK FOUR — OF SEALS AND RECORD

Book Four names forging an imperial instrument — a seal, a signet, a writ, a chartered license — as an offense in its own right, distinct from whatever fraud the forgery enables: restitution plus a term of indenture (Book One's second tier) scaled to the value of what was falsely authorized, escalating to exile from the offending jurisdiction on a second offense. Every chartered license, and every signet issued for identification, is dual-recorded exactly as Book Three requires: the physical mark, and an entry in the issuing body's own register. Copying wax is easy. Copying a Chartered Scriptorium's register, an almonry's ledger, or an academy's roll is a fundamentally harder crime — which is exactly why Rivergate deals in provenance rather than fabrication.

An office that ceases to exist must surrender its seal formally to the Imperial Archive before its authority lapses; only after surrender may the retired instrument change hands as a curio. It is a small, dry clause, and it is the entire reason a trade like Tirell Mosse's — dealer in the seals, signets, and letterheads of forty defunct institutions — is a legitimate one and not a smuggling operation.

BOOK FIVE — OF THE WOLF

Book Five is the shortest of the seven, because it changes nothing: it simply gives the existing Wolf-Price statute (see The Wolf-Price: Blood Debts and the Provinces, above) formal standing among the Laws rather than leaving it to stand alone. Self-defense remains a full defense against a wolf-killing charge, reported to a magistrate within three days with the body produced or accounted for; the older, non-legal debt to the nearest shrine-keeper remains exactly as it was.

BOOK SIX — OF THE MARCH

Book Six is military law, narrow by design: every subject owes the empire service in some form, deliberately undefined in scope (see The Vision of Restoration, above); border-lord and warlord private forces are tolerated as a fact of the fracture rather than licensed; and an officer who defrauds his own command is triable by court-martial at Legate level, appealable once to Aenodira — the exact mechanism Magistrate Ondrei’s complaint against Colonel Dessen has been waiting on.

The Book also gives the legions’ chain of command formal shape for the first time:

Rank	Command	Body
Legionary	Self	Imperial Legions
Sergeant	~10 (a file)	Any regular force
Centurion	~80–100 (a company)	Imperial Legions
Colonel	A garrison or single legion	Imperial Legions
Legate	Multiple legions, or the capital’s standing force; answers directly to the Throne	Imperial Legions / Palatine Guard
Censor / Censor-Captain	A detachment of Office Examiners	Office of Omens’ military arm

Marshal is not a rung on this ladder. It is an acclamation the Throne grants a field commander for extraordinary personal renown, entirely apart from the size of the force under him — which is why Gavric Dane, who commands a single march’s garrison, is styled Marshal while Legate Thorne, who commands the Palatine Guard itself, is not. Dane holds a Colonel’s actual authority and a Marshal’s public weight, and the gap between the two is precisely what makes the court’s quiet anxiety about him a structural fact rather than an unexplained rumor.

Provincial and warlord forces carry no standard rank of their own; “Captain” serves empire-wide as a courtesy title for anyone commanding a company-sized irregular force — a border lord’s retinue, a warlord company, a Sarkanni mercenary contract-officer — without implying any place in the legions’ ladder at all.

BOOK SEVEN — OF JUDGMENT

Book Seven answers the question every provincial town already answers in practice without a name for it. There is no separate civilian watch in the Crownlands or the loyalist provinces: order-keeping is a standing duty of whatever legion or garrison detachment is posted locally, and in Aenodira itself, of the Palatine Guard. A magistrate — judge and civil administrator combined in a single office, as Cassivar Ondrei already is in Dravenna — receives complaints, hears testimony (a witnessed oath carries real evidentiary weight under Book Two; a false one is perjury, not merely a bad witness), and rules without a jury. Sentencing runs the Laws’ own ranges: fines, restitution, indenture under Book One, rarely worse.

Appeal to Aenodira exists, and Book Seven does nothing to make it fast — Ondrei’s complaint against Colonel Dessen is itself the proof, still sitting in Legate Thorne’s inbox years on. Secular justice and the Church’s own process (the Office of Omens’ escalating Writ of Examination) run in parallel and can conflict; a sufficient political favor can have a writ quashed as obstruction of an open imperial inquiry, but only as an exceptional intervention from above, never as a routine appeal.

Outside the loyalist provinces, in thin country, there is often no resident magistrate at all, and disputes fall to whoever locally holds informal authority — a village elder, or the same shrine-keeper who already judges the Wolf-Price, called on for grievances that have nothing to do with wolves. In the Brekelands, and anywhere warlord-held, there is no magistrate and no appeal: the warlord or his captains are judge, jury, and enforcement, full stop.

TITLES, RANKS, AND PRECEDENCE

The empire has never kept a single order of precedence, and the omission is not an oversight. Two centuries of fracture left the Lupine Throne granting titles it can no longer enforce and recognizing titles it never granted, so that a Voivode and a Duke are not two rungs of one ladder but the heads of two different kinds of thing. What follows is five ladders, each running to its own summit, and one honest rule for what happens where they cross.

THE THRONE AND THE COURT

Precedence at court is by access. This is the first thing a provincial learns in Aenodira and the last thing he believes: rank on paper decides where a man stands at a rite, but who reaches the Emperor decides everything else — and the man who decides who reaches the Emperor commands no soldiers, holds no land, and is one of the most powerful people in the empire.

Style	Office	Held by
Emperor / Empress	The Lupine Throne	Qilvayas; Nyreeza, missing three years
Lord Chamberlain	Keeper of access to the Emperor’s person	Vareth Kessin
Archjurist	Head of the Law Commission drafting the Zhuvedian Laws	Senna Vhal
Mistress / Master	The style of a commoner who heads an imperial bureau	Averil Shen, Keeper of the Bureau of Correspondence
Magistrate	Judge and civil administrator in one office (Book Seven)	Cassivar Ondrei of Dravenna

Master and Mistress are not courtesies but a precise legal style: they mark a commoner holding an imperial bureau in her own right, as against the noble officers of the household. Averil Shen is Mistress Shen because she is not a lady and

has never once pretended to be. The Bureau is hers by appointment and competence, and the style says so.

THE LEGIONS

The one ladder the empire has already written down is the legions', set out in Book Six — Of the March, above: Legionary, Sergeant, Centurion, Colonel, Legate. Marshal stands outside that ladder as an acclamation of the Throne, and Captain serves empire-wide as a courtesy for anyone commanding an irregular company. Book Six is the authority; nothing here amends it.

THE CHURCH OF THE LUPINE MATRON

Style	Authority
Matriarch	Voice of the Matron in Aenodira; the Church's most senior public figure
Synod of the Grey	Council of senior clergy; advises the Matriarch, and constrains her
Prelate	Head of a Church office of jurisdiction — Sarvin Odell, the Office of Omens
Hierophant	Head of the Keepers of the Ascent — the imperial cult, a parallel body and not Church clergy

The Church has no single supreme authority, and this is a decision rather than a vacancy. The Matriarchate is collegial: the Matron's Voice speaks for the faith in the capital and is checked at every turn by the Synod of the Grey, which exists precisely so that no one throat holds the whole of it. A Prelate therefore holds his jurisdiction from the Synod and not from the Matriarch personally — her colleague with his own writ, not her subordinate. This is why the Office of Omens can pursue a policy the Matriarch has not endorsed and cannot simply countermand, and why anyone hoping to appeal over Prelate Odell's head will spend a long and instructive season discovering there is no head to appeal over.

THE IMPERIAL ACADEMY

Style	Role
Chancellor	Head of the Academy — Emeth Sorral
Professor	Senior faculty, often holding a named charge — Corvin Dail, Master of Trials
Professor Emeritus	Retired faculty; the style is kept for life, whatever the circumstances of departure
Instructor	Junior faculty — Liria Fenn, House of the Craft
Archivist	Keeper of the restricted stacks — Dathenor Vell

SOVEREIGN AND BORDER STYLES

These do not rank against one another, and none of them ranks beneath the Throne except where the Throne can make it so. Each style records what kind of power it is.

Style	What it means	Held by
King	A crown claiming full sovereignty	Karvel of Ardven

Style	What it means	Held by
Sea-King	King of a people rather than a territory: no land, no seat, no grave	Aldrec the Landless
Voivode	Tarnovar's war-leader raised to sovereign; absolute within her word	Ysavet Morn
Ban	A march-warden holding a frontier for a Voivode, with wide latitude and little supervision	Dregan Morn, the Eastmarch
Duke / Duchess	An imperial ducal house — a title the Throne granted, whether or not it is still obeyed	Garvin Norr of Normere; the Suthmark house
Count / Countess	A landed noble seated beneath a ducal house	Velsanna Ory of Greywell
Lord	Any landholder with retainers and no better title	Ostrev, on the eastern road
Saint-Regent	Unique to Olvesa: the See's regency of the True Rite	Olvesa the Reconciled
Harborlord	One of Velmareth's ruling merchant-bankers	the Meldane house among them
Guildmaster	Head of a chartered trade body	Ptolan Vess, Capital Merchants' Concord

The distinction that matters most is the one nobody says aloud. Duke Norr and Voivode Morn are not peers of unequal rank; they hold different kinds of title entirely. Norr's is imperial — granted by the Lupine Throne, which makes him on paper the Emperor's own subject, conducting a rival restoration inside the empire's own law. Morn's is foreign, and owes Aenodira nothing whatsoever. That asymmetry is the reason Normere is the more dangerous of the two: a Voivode who defies the Throne is a neighbor, while a Duke who does it is a precedent.

WHEN THE LADDERS MEET

A Prelate, a Legate, and a Duchess share no scale at all, and they meet constantly. The empire's practical answer is unwritten and none the weaker for it: precedence at court is by access, precedence in the provinces is by force, and precedence in a shrine is by rite. What happens when those three disagree has never been set down. The Zhuvedian Laws, which have an opinion about grain weights and the wolf-price alike, are conspicuously silent here — and the silence is not something Archjurist Vhal has overlooked. It is the one question she has been told not to answer, because answering it would oblige the Throne to say out loud whose empire this is.

FORMS OF ADDRESS

Speaking to	Say
The Emperor	Your Radiance, in form; Majesty, in the shorthand of a court that uses it daily

Speaking to	Say
A King, Voivode, or Sea-King	Your Grace
A Duke, Duchess, or Ban	Your Grace
A Count, Countess, or Lord	My lord; my lady
The Matriarch	Your Voice
A Prelate or Hierophant	Your Reverence
Saint-Regent Olvesa	Mother — the See uses nothing grander, at her insistence
A Legate or Marshal	Legate; Marshal. The legions do not embroider
A Magistrate	Your Honor
Academy faculty	Professor; Instructor

Getting one of these wrong is not a crime and rarely even an insult. Getting one deliberately wrong — calling Olvesa Your Holiness, or naming Dregan Ban of the Fence to his face — is a sentence with a knife in it, and every soul in the room will hear it land.

THE IMPERIAL ACADEMY OF THE LUPINE THRONE

PURPOSE AND HISTORY

The Imperial Academy was originally founded during the empire's golden age to train the administrators, officers, and specialists needed to govern and defend such a vast realm. Like much else, it fell into decline as the empire fractured — many regional academies closed, curricula degraded, and standards slipped.

Empress Nyreeza began the academy's revival in the years before her disappearance, recognizing that rebuilding imperial institutions required trained personnel. Emperor Qilvayas has continued and expanded this effort, seeing the academy as essential to his restoration plans. He needs loyal, competent people who understand his vision and can implement his reforms across the empire.

Today, multiple Imperial Academies exist across territories that still recognize the throne, but the Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne in the capital remains the most prestigious. Studying at the capital academy means access to the best instructors, the imperial library and archives, proximity to power, and the possibility of advancement in imperial service. Graduation from the capital academy opens doors that provincial schools cannot match.

ADMISSION AND STUDENT BODY

The empire maintains a policy of universal education — in theory, any subject can seek admission to an Imperial Academy. In practice, admission to the capital academy operates through a lottery system that is less fair than it appears:

The Official Process: Applicants from across the empire enter their names into an annual lottery for admission. The system is designed to give opportunity to talented individuals regardless of birth or wealth.

The Reality: Wealthy families make generous “donations” to the academy, and their children mysteriously get selected. Local lords ensure their favored protégés gain admission. Some slots are reserved for hostage-diplomacy situations — sons and daughters of border lords and ambitious nobles kept close to ensure good behavior. But enough legitimate lottery winners make it through that the system maintains its legitimacy and the student body remains genuinely diverse.

This creates a fascinating mix: children of privilege alongside scholarship students who earned their place, hostages resentful of being pawns alongside true believers in the empire, ambitious commoners seeking advancement alongside nobility maintaining family traditions. The academy deliberately fosters this diversity, believing that future imperial servants need to understand and work with people from all backgrounds.

THE THREE HOUSES

The Imperial Academy is organized into three houses, each focusing on different areas of study necessary for imperial service. Students affiliate with a primary house based on their chosen career path but regularly cross-train in the other houses as their profession requires.

HOUSE OF THE SWORD

The House of the Sword trains officers, strategists, and those who will serve in martial or military capacities. The curriculum emphasizes not just combat skills but the art of leading, organizing, and sustaining military forces.

Core Studies: Military tactics and strategy, logistics and supply chain management, leadership and command, military history and analysis of historical campaigns, fortification and siege warfare, cavalry and infantry doctrine, naval operations (where relevant).

Practical Training: Physical conditioning, weapons training, small unit tactics, command exercises with actual troops, war games and simulations.

Typical Career Paths: Imperial legion officers, garrison commanders, military advisors to provincial governors, personal guards to nobility, mercenary company leaders, military engineers (with Craft cross-training), battlefield chaplains (with Seal cross-training).

HOUSE OF THE SEAL

The House of the Seal focuses on administration, law, theology, and governance — the civilian machinery that keeps an empire functioning. These students will become the magistrates, tax collectors, diplomats, and priests who actually run imperial territories day-to-day.

Core Studies: Imperial law and the Zhuvedian legal codes, theology and doctrine of the Lupine Matron, rhetoric and persuasion, diplomacy and negotiation, taxation and fiscal policy, record-keeping and bureaucratic procedure, history and philosophy of governance.

Practical Training: Mock trials and legal proceedings, diplomatic simulations, public speaking and debate, religious ceremonies and rituals, administrative case studies.

Typical Career Paths: Magistrates and judges, imperial bureaucrats and administrators, tax collectors and treasury officials, diplomats and ambassadors, priests and religious officials, legal scholars, court advisors, intelligence officers (with Craft cross-training).

HOUSE OF THE CRAFT

The House of the Craft is the most diverse and internally varied, encompassing anyone whose skills serve the empire but don't fit neatly into military command or civil administration. The unifying principle is practical application — these are people who make things, solve problems, and get specialized work done.

Core Studies (varies by specialization): Engineering and architecture, medicine and surgery, alchemy and herbalism, cartography and surveying, languages and linguistics, codes and ciphers, arcane theory and spellcraft, artifice and magical item creation, trade and economics, arts and propaganda.

The Role of Magic: Most arcane and divine casters at the academy study in House of the Craft, as magic is treated as another specialized skill to be mastered and applied. Wizards study spellcraft and magical theory, clerics and paladins study theology (though they may take courses in the Seal as well), druids study natural philosophy, and artificers combine magical and mundane engineering.

Practical Training: Hands-on projects relevant to specialization, apprenticeships with master craftsmen or mages, field exercises applying skills in real situations.

Typical Career Paths: Imperial engineers and architects, court physicians and healers, alchemists and apothecaries, cartographers and explorers, spies and intelligence operatives, war wizards (with Sword cross-training), trade negotiators, artists and cultural ambassadors, artificers and enchanters.

CLASS PLACEMENT BY HOUSE

For character creation purposes, the thirteen base classes align with the houses as follows. Primary house reflects the class's core training; nearly every character concept will involve cross-training.

House of the Sword: Barbarian, Fighter, Monk. Paladins may choose Sword as primary if their concept is a warrior shaped by faith rather than a religious figure trained for war.

House of the Seal: Paladins who see themselves foremost as religious champions — think warrior-clergy in the Byzantine mold — may take Seal as primary with heavy Sword cross-training. Clerics with a doctrinal or pastoral focus may also justify Seal primary.

House of the Craft: Artificer, Bard (arts and propaganda), Cleric (divine magic, with substantial Seal cross-training in theology), Druid (natural philosophy), Ranger (wilderness operations), Rogue (espionage, codes, intelligence), Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard.

The imbalance toward Craft is intentional — it is explicitly the catch-all house for specialists, and magic is institutionally treated as a specialized skill rather than a separate estate.

Players should choose primary house based on character concept, with the paladin placement left deliberately flexible.

CROSS-TRAINING AND CURRICULUM STRUCTURE

The academy's philosophy emphasizes cooperation between houses. The empire needs soldiers who understand law, administrators who respect military realities, and specialists who can work with both. To this end, cross-training is common and often required:

A military supply officer studies primarily in the Sword (logistics, military operations) but takes extensive coursework in the Seal (procurement law, contracts) and Craft (engineering, trade).

A battlefield medic is primarily Craft (medicine) with Sword secondary (understanding military operations, triage under fire).

A combat engineer focuses on Craft (engineering, fortifications) with Sword training (siege warfare, military architecture).

An intelligence officer might be Craft primary (espionage, languages, codes) with courses in both Seal (diplomacy, law) and Sword (military intelligence).

A military chaplain studies Seal (theology, law) with Sword coursework (military hierarchy, morale, battlefield ministry).

This flexibility allows the academy to train highly specialized professionals while ensuring they can work effectively across disciplines — crucial for serving a complex empire.

DORMITORIES AND SOCIAL STRUCTURE

Rather than segregating students by house, the academy deliberately assigns them to mixed residential halls based on year and cohort. This ensures that students from all three houses live, eat, and socialize together, breaking down professional silos and building the kind of cross-disciplinary relationships that effective imperial service requires.

Dormitory Facilities: Each residential hall includes communal dining areas, study rooms and libraries, courtyards for exercise and sparring, small shrines to the Lupine Matron, common rooms for socializing and recreation.

Social Dynamics: The dormitories are where lasting friendships form, where rivalries develop, and where students learn to see beyond house loyalties. Study groups mix houses, athletic competitions pit house against house for prestige, and social networks cross professional boundaries.

Despite official encouragement of cooperation, house pride remains strong. Informal competitions, debates over which house is most essential to the empire, and good-natured (and sometimes not-so-good-natured) rivalries are part of academy culture.

PROGRAM DURATION AND FIELD EXERCISES

The standard academy program lasts four years. Students typically enter around age 18-20 (human equivalent) and graduate in their early twenties, ready to begin imperial service or pursue other paths.

First and Second Years: Foundation coursework in primary house, introduction to cross-training, basic practical skills, intensive study and classroom work.

Third Year: Advanced specialized study, deeper cross-training, more complex projects and simulations, beginning of practical application.

Fourth Year (Final Year): Students complete supervised field exercises — real-world assignments that prove they can apply their training outside the safety of the academy. These might include serving with imperial legions on patrol, assisting magistrates in provincial courts, conducting surveys or diplomatic missions, solving problems for local authorities, or taking on adventuring contracts that serve imperial interests.

Field exercises serve multiple purposes: they test competence under real conditions, build confidence and practical skills, create opportunities for students to distinguish themselves, and provide the empire with useful work from advanced students at minimal cost. Students often work in small mixed-house teams during these exercises, mirroring how they might operate in actual imperial service.

POST-GRADUATION EXPECTATIONS

All subjects of the empire are expected to serve, though the definition of “service” is deliberately vague and enforcement uneven in the fractured realm:

Direct Imperial Service: Accepting commissions as officers, magistrates, engineers, or other official imperial positions. This is what the academy ideally produces.

Regional Service: Returning home to serve local lords or territorial governments, technically fulfilling the service requirement without necessarily strengthening the central throne.

Guild and Civic Service: Joining craftsmen’s guilds, merchant associations, or other civic organizations that serve “the empire” in an abstract sense.

Independent Operations: Striking out as adventurers, mercenaries, merchants, or specialists, often rationalizing that protecting imperial citizens and interests counts as service.

Ignoring the Obligation: Some graduates simply pursue their own interests with no pretense of service, betting correctly that the weakened empire can’t enforce compliance everywhere.

The academy cannot and does not force specific career paths. Graduates make their own choices, though those who openly flout their obligations may find doors closed if they later seek imperial favor or positions.

THE PROVING (DM ONLY)

The capital academy maintains one tradition no student is ever told about: the Proving, a staged final examination administered irregularly, and only to cohorts the faculty judge exceptional. The chosen cohort receives what appears to be a genuine, dangerous commission — and completes it inside a controlled environment they believe is real, observed throughout by the faculty. The academy’s reasoning is coldly

sound: an examination a student knows is an examination measures preparation; only a test mistaken for reality measures judgment, mercy, leadership, and nerve. Graduates who pass are told at the conclusion, sworn to secrecy about the method, and marked in sealed records as Proven — a designation certain offices in Highcourt know to look for. The party’s Proving is the subject of Sessions Three and Four (see the session module *The Proving Below*). The thematic rhyme — a benevolent institution deceiving its own for reasons it believes justify the deception, inside an empire founded on exactly that logic — is deliberate, and should never be stated aloud at the table. Let it sit.

THE PLAYER CHARACTERS

WHO THEY ARE

The player characters are final-year students at the Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne, currently completing their field exercises. They come from diverse backgrounds — some from loyal imperial territories, others from breakaway regions or neutral ground. Some earned their admission through the lottery, others through family influence or political arrangement. They may have different primary houses and specializations, but their time together at the academy — sharing dormitories, working on cross-training projects, competing in house competitions — has forged them into a cohesive unit.

They are competent but not yet famous — skilled enough to handle dangerous situations but still learning, still making mistakes, still figuring out who they are and what they believe. They represent the future Emperor Qilvayas is trying to build: capable, educated individuals who understand both the ideals of the empire and the messy reality of the fractured world.

THEIR PLANS

The party has decided that after graduation, they will form their own adventuring company — a mercenary band operating under the principle that “a job is a job and coin is coin.” This represents a choice to be masters of their own fate rather than following predetermined paths into imperial bureaucracy, military service, or guild positions.

Their academy training makes them uniquely qualified for this work. They can handle diverse challenges — combat, negotiation, investigation, problem-solving — and their cross-training means they work together seamlessly despite different specializations. In the chaos of the fractured empire, there’s always work for capable people willing to take on dangerous jobs that “decent folk may not wish to risk themselves to do.”

They might rationalize this as serving imperial interests (protecting imperial citizens, maintaining order, gathering intelligence) or simply be honest that they prefer freedom and profit over institutional service. Either way, they’re planning to strike out independently once they complete their final exercises and officially graduate.

But fate — or the gods, or something else — has other plans for them.

THE INCITING INCIDENT: THE SHARED VISION

THE VISION ITSELF

After completing their latest field exercise and celebrating with the profits from their client, the party retires to their inn for the night. During sleep, each character receives the same vision — or perhaps nightmare:

Dark storm clouds gather over the imperial capital. The city below burns with infernal flames — not natural fire, but something wrong, something that shouldn't exist in the mortal world. The characters are present in the vision but powerless, unable to move or speak, only able to witness in horror.

Their gaze is drawn upward to the storm clouds. Behind the roiling darkness lurks an immense shadow — not just large, but vast, world-shaking, wrong. It emanates a roar that resonates in their bones, that speaks of ancient power and terrible purpose. The characters cannot scream, cannot flee, cannot do anything but watch until the vision fades to blackness and they awaken drenched in sweat.

When they compare notes, they realize with growing unease that they all experienced exactly the same vision, down to the smallest details. This is no ordinary dream.

THE RESPONSE

Despite their academy training, the party has no frame of reference for this. Shared prophetic visions aren't part of the curriculum. But they know someone who might have answers: quiet word among academy scholars and capital contacts speaks of a Seeress in the city — a woman named Vaelindra, once of the Church, now independent — who is consulted discreetly by people of consequence when omens defy explanation. She is not advertised; she is referred. Finding her is the party's first step.

The vision has marked them. Whether they want it or not, they are now connected to something larger than their plans for an independent mercenary company. The capital calls, and with it, their destiny.

They must travel to the capital — back to the heart of the empire they thought they'd left behind — and seek answers from the Seeress. What they learn there will determine not just their own futures, but perhaps the fate of the Empire of Zhuvedus itself.

CAMPAIGN THEMES AND POTENTIAL DIRECTIONS

CORE THEMES

The Qilvayas Symphony explores several interconnected themes:

Legacy and Restoration: Can past glory be reclaimed? Should it be? What is lost in the attempt to restore what was?

Idealism vs. Reality: The tension between Qilvayas's noble vision and the compromises that achieving it might require. When does pragmatism become corruption? When does necessary force become tyranny?

Prophecy and Free Will: The party has seen a potential future. Can it be changed? Should it be? Are they agents of destiny or masters of their own fate?

Unity vs. Freedom: Is imperial reunification worth the cost to those who have built new lives in the fractured territories? Does order justify the loss of autonomy?

Power and Its Corruption: What happens when good intentions meet the brutal realities of power? How do individuals and institutions change when pursuing righteous goals through questionable means?

POSSIBLE INTERPRETATIONS OF THE VISION

The shadow creature in the vision can be developed in several directions, depending on the tone and focus of the campaign:

The Empire's Dark Reflection: The shadow represents what the empire becomes if Qilvayas's methods grow too brutal. The infernal flames are purges and forced compliance. The vision is a warning about the cost of restoration — showing the party what they might need to prevent or oppose.

Ancient Power Unleashed: The Lupine Throne or some imperial regalia contains a bound entity or dark pact from the empire's founding. Qilvayas, desperate to save the empire, might reach for this power without understanding the consequences. The vision shows the result of that choice.

External Existential Threat: The shadow is real, literal, and coming — an ancient enemy, a planar incursion, or something awakening. Only a unified empire has any chance of surviving, justifying Qilvayas's urgency but also forcing terrible choices about how quickly reunification must happen.

Theological Crisis: The shadow represents corruption spreading through the faith of the Lupine Matron — heresy, false prophets, or something masquerading as divine will. The vision warns of spiritual catastrophe that could destroy the empire from within.

Combination or Misdirection: The truth might combine elements from multiple interpretations, or the vision itself might be incomplete or intentionally misleading, sent by forces with their own agendas.

Working answer for DM reference: the shadow is a fusion of the personal and the impersonal — Threnvos's dying essence bound to the force unleashed by Zhuvedus's broken oath, fed since by every betrayal the fractured empire has produced. See The Founding Myth: Zhuvedus and the Broken Oath for the full account. This should not be revealed to players outright; let them arrive at pieces of it through Vaelindra, Nyreeza's trail, and whatever they eventually find beneath the capital.

POTENTIAL CAMPAIGN ARCS

The campaign can develop in various directions based on player choices and interests:

Agents of the Empire: The party works with (or for) Qilvayas, helping implement his reforms, dealing with threats to reunification, and navigating the moral complexities of restoration. They become key players in imperial politics.

Independent Investigators: The party pursues their original plan of independence but finds themselves repeatedly drawn into events connected to the vision. They operate in the spaces between factions, making their own choices about which side to support in any given situation.

Opposition to Empire: If Qilvayas's methods become tyrannical or the vision reveals dark truths about imperial restoration, the party might actively work against reunification, supporting breakaway territories or seeking alternative solutions.

Preventing Catastrophe: If the shadow represents an actual external or supernatural threat, the party might focus on investigating and preventing the catastrophe shown in their vision, regardless of political implications.

The campaign's tone allows for moral complexity — there may be no clear “right” answer to whether the empire should be restored, what methods are justified, or even whether the vision's warning can or should be heeded. The party will need to make difficult choices with imperfect information, and their decisions will have real consequences for the empire and its people.

KEY NPCs AND FACTIONS

VAELINDRA OF THE STILL WATERS — THE SEERESS

Role in the Campaign: The first major NPC the party meaningfully interacts with. She validates the shared vision, reframes it as potential rather than prophecy, and becomes a recurring resource, moral compass, and eventual source of one of the campaign's most significant revelations.

WHO SHE IS

Vaelindra is an elderly human woman — late seventies, perhaps older, difficult to tell — who has lived in the capital long enough to have watched three rulers come and go, including Empress Nyreeza. She was not always the Seeress. She arrived in the capital decades ago as a minor functionary in the Church of the Lupine Matron, bright and ambitious, until her first genuine vision destroyed her career. What she saw conflicted with Church interests; the hierarchy quietly sidelined her, and she has operated independently ever since — not quite official, not quite heretical, merely tolerated. Powerful people consult her quietly and would never admit it publicly.

PRESENTATION AND MANNER

She is deliberately unmythical. No dramatic robes, no incense-filled chamber of mystery. She lives in a comfortable but modest apartment in a middle district of the capital, keeps meticulous written records of every vision she has

ever interpreted, and receives visitors like a retired scholar receiving students. She is sharp, a little sardonic, and asks more questions than she answers. She has seen enough prophecy go wrong — interpreted incorrectly, weaponized politically, fulfilled in ways nobody anticipated — that she is deeply cautious about telling people what their visions “mean.”

HER GIFT

Her gift is genuine. She receives true visions from time to time, and she has an uncanny ability to recognize patterns across different people's prophetic experiences. When the party describes their shared vision, she will recognize elements she has encountered before — not the same vision, but related imagery, similar symbolic language. This unsettles her deeply, because it suggests something much larger than a personal omen: something already in motion.

WHAT SHE TELLS THE PARTY

She does not interpret the vision so much as confirm its legitimacy and share what she knows of its imagery. The shadow, the infernal fire, the burning capital — she has seen fragments of this before. She can tell the party the vision is real and connected to events already unfolding. But she pushes back firmly on the assumption that it is a prophecy of inevitable doom. In her experience, shared visions do not show what will happen — they show what could happen if nothing changes. This distinction preserves the party's agency: they are not spectators to a predetermined script but actors who may yet change the outcome.

RELATIONSHIP WITH THE THRONE

Her most complicated entanglement is with the imperial family. Empress Nyreeza consulted her regularly, and Vaelindra was one of the last people to see the Empress before her disappearance. She has never spoken of that final meeting to anyone. Emperor Qilvayas knows she exists and knows his mother trusted her, but he has never sought her out — possibly because he fears what she might tell him.

HER SECRET (DM ONLY)

Vaelindra's career-ending vision, decades ago, showed her fragments of the empire's true founding account — Zhuvedus, the broken oath, and the rival he destroyed to seize it (see The Founding Myth: Zhuvedus and the Broken Oath). That is precisely what the Church could not tolerate, and precisely why she was sidelined rather than elevated. She and Empress Nyreeza discussed this in their final meeting, and Vaelindra believes Nyreeza went looking for confirmation, or for the site itself, shortly before she vanished. Vaelindra also believes that Qilvayas's restoration project, however genuinely motivated, risks repeating his ancestor's exact error — that in his urgency to reunify the empire through law and order, he may yet break faith the way Zhuvedus once did, and accelerate the very conditions that lead to the burning capital of the vision. She has not decided what to do with this knowledge, or whether the party can be trusted with it. This revelation should be deployed at a dramatically appropriate moment mid-campaign, once the party has earned her trust — or forced her hand.

RESOLVED DESIGN NOTES

How the party learns of her: resolved — Archivist Vell's referral (Session Two).

Church posture: resolved — active conflict. The Office of Omens surveils her (the ground-floor copyist reports to the Office; she knows, and feeds it chaff) and moves to a Writ of Examination in Session Six.

Her knowledge depth: resolved by tier — she knows the shape (the founding was a burial; the wound lies beneath; Nyreeza sought it) but withholds names and specifics until earned. Her forced-hand partial revelation is Session Six; the full account remains a mid-campaign payoff.

THE POWERS OF THE FRACTURED EMPIRE

Races, classes, and full stat blocks for the figures below appear in Appendices I–II. The rulers, commanders, and monsters who define the territories of the Atlas. Each profile notes its historical key — the real figure whose life supplies its spine — for the DM's reference in improvising beyond what is written.

DM Only — The Acceleration: One pattern connects these profiles, and no one on the board can see it. The shadow beneath Aenodira has been stirring since Empress Nyreeza reached the binding site three years ago — and its stirring leaks. Vaelindra's ledger records the visions quickening; Saint-Regent Olvesa's visions darkened the same season, which is why Orlath's coronation is suddenly imminent; the ancient green Vessarkath, still couched on the eagles she took sixty years past, chose that same season to let one leave her hoard, and the empire's Young Wolf was made downstream of it; the dreams that drive Ban Dregan's cruelty have worsened; the Skellvard's displacement, Norr's conquests, and the court's brittleness all sharpen in an empire growing subtly more faithless, more frightened, and more willing to break its word. The whole board is moving faster, and the players' campaign is the reason why. Never state this; let the tempo itself be the tell.

SEA-KING ALDREC THE LANDLESS — LORD OF THE SKELLVARD CLANS

Historical key: Alaric I. Aldrec, in his fifties now, served the empire as a young man, and for twenty years after — Skell oarsmen and shock-fighters were cheap, and at the Weeping Strait, twenty years ago, an imperial admiral spent three thousand of them to save his own squadrons and logged it as victory. Aldrec survived, was denied the coastal command he had been promised, and went home to find the fjords already under pressure from the northern crowns as they then were; Karvel's consolidation of those crowns into Arduven, some five years later, would only finish what was begun. He has led the ship-clans ever since as a king without a country, raiding the coast of the empire he would rather serve. His demands have never changed: a coastal march to hold, a title to hold it by, and his people's names entered in the empire's rolls as subjects rather than vermin. The throne has refused him four times — each refusal recorded, like everything, on the tally-sticks his lawspeakers keep. Speech pattern: fluent, formal Imperial — better than most courtiers' — which unsettles people who expected a savage; he counts silently in Skell when angry.

Threads: Aldrec is the campaign's great persuadable — the enemy who wants to be an ally, whom the empire keeps manufacturing into a threat. If Qilvayas grants him his march, the coast gains its fiercest defender and the restoration its strangest proof of concept. If refused too long, Aldrec will do something vast and terrible that solves nothing — and he

knows it, which is the tragedy. **DM Only:** he is dying slowly of an old wound gone bad, and his succession is unsettled; the clans after Aldrec will not negotiate. The window he represents closes with him. Skell kings are buried under rivers, in secret; his greatest private fear is dying landless, with no river his people may safely turn.

MARSHAL GAVRIC DANE — THE YOUNG WOLF OF THE OSTMARK

Historical key: Germanicus. Gavric Dane is not yet thirty-five and already the most beloved soldier in the empire: the man who led the expedition that recovered the wolf-standard of the Ninth from the Brekelands, nearly sixty years after the Silvasse Disaster swallowed three legions and every banner they carried. He weeps openly at soldiers' funerals, remembers the names of privates' children, refuses gifts he cannot reciprocate, and has never once, in any recorded word, expressed an ambition beyond his command — which is precisely why half the court is certain he must be hiding one. The legions call him the Young Wolf. The court hears that name and thinks of succession. The Emperor has met him twice, decorated him twice, and both times been perfectly, studiously correct — two disciplined young men, each aware the other is watching. Speech pattern: warm, direct, remembers everyone; goes quiet rather than lies.

Threads: Dane is a loyalty test the campaign can pose to every faction, including the party — everyone wants to claim him, use him, or remove him. **DM Only:** the Piso gun on the mantel — if Dane ever dies suddenly, the empire will tear itself apart over who is to blame, and at least three factions (the court, Orlath's agents, Norr) could plausibly want it. Whether that gun ever fires is the DM's call; its existence should shadow every scene he is in. He has begun having bad dreams he tells no one about. He has never broken an oath in his life. The shadow has no purchase on him — yet — and something in the dark finds that interesting.

BAN DREGAN MORN — WARDEN OF THE EASTMARCH, LORD OF THE FENCE

Historical key: Vlad III. Kinsman to Voivode Ysavet Morn, sent to the capital academy as a hostage-student forty years ago under the admission system's quiet diplomacy, returned to Tarnovar with perfect Imperial manners and something broken behind the eyes. For thirty years he has held the Eastmarch — Tarnovar's frontier with the Brekelands — and made it the safest road in the fractured west by a method the whole continent knows: the Fence, a mile of stakes along the border hills, and on the stakes, oath-breakers. Bandits who violated surrender terms. Mercenaries who turned on their employers. A Brekeland captain who burned a village under parley-sign. Tarnovari law makes oath-breaking the one unforgivable crime; Dregan enforces the law. Merchants bless his name. Peasants cross the border toward him. The Voivode has never sanctioned the Fence and never dismantled it, and that silence is the central fact of Tarnovari politics. Speech pattern: soft, courteous, academy-perfect Imperial; never raises his voice; asks questions he already knows the answers to.

Threads: Dregan is the campaign's question about order made flesh — Qilvayas restores through law, Norr through conquest, Dregan through terror in the name of the kept word, and the roads are safest in Dregan's march. **DM Only:** as a son of Threnvos's people, Dregan's obsessive punishment of oath-breakers is ancestral scar tissue he cannot name — and it has consequences he cannot see: the

shadow, which feeds on broken oaths, finds the Eastmarch barren ground, and the nightmares that afflict oath-breakers cluster strangely at his border. He has noticed that the men he stakes die dreaming of a burning city. He has begun to wonder, in his cold patient way, what is listening. Of every soul on the board, Dregan is closest to guessing the campaign's secret from first principles.

DUCHESS EMERENN VASQ, NÉE MELDANE — THE DOWAGER OF THE SUTHMARK

Historical key: Catherine de' Medici. Born to Velmareth's great Meldane banking house, married young into the Suthmark's ducal line to seal a grain-and-credit compact, widowed at forty some fifteen years ago, and Dowager Duchess ever since — a style that carries no authority whatever. The Suthmark's duke is her elder son; every instrument of rule is his, and she has governed through her sons regardless — the sickly young Duke Aldous, and his ambitious younger brother, Tavian. The devout south never fully accepted the merchant's daughter, and she never asked it to; she governs through the Garland, her web of ladies-in-waiting, governesses, wine-factors, and priests' housekeepers, which knows what the Suthmark is thinking before the Suthmark does. Her defining wound is the Vintage Night, six years past: Orlathine congregations massacred in three towns during the harvest festival. She gave an order that night — what she meant by it and what it became are not the same thing — and rather than be seen to have lost control, she let the realm believe she meant all of it. The Suthmark fears her now. She has decided fear will serve. Speech pattern: exquisitely courteous; deploys her dead husband's opinions as cover for her own; switches to Velmarene idiom when she wants you to know the courtesy has ended.

Threads: Vasq holds the capital's food supply, which makes her patience the empire's most strategic resource. She bridges three regions — Meldane money in Velmareth, Suthmark grain, and the Orlath schism bleeding into her provinces — and she has quietly opened her own channels to Orlath, not from sympathy but because she hedges everything. **DM Only:** the truth of the Vintage Night order — now canon: a limited arrest that cascaded into massacre, which she chose to own rather than be seen to have lost control — is her breakable point — proof of what she actually said exists in a Garland lady's cipher-diary, and its surfacing would either humanize or destroy her. She knows about Countess Ory's hill country and its vanishing girls; she has done nothing, because the Ory estates hold Vasq debts, and she is waiting for the accusation to become profitable. The gothic horror in her south is, to her, an account not yet due.

THE SUTHMARK'S SONS — DUKE ALDOUS AND TAVIAN VASQ

Duke Aldous Vasq is twenty-six, and has been dying since he was nine without ever managing it — a wasting complaint of the chest that his mother has spent a fortune failing to cure, and that three certified physicians have confidently named three different things. He rules by signature from a warm room, and rules better than the capital assumes: he reads every instrument that crosses his desk, forgets nothing that was in it, and his reeves are honest because they have learned he will notice. He has never ridden at the head of anything and never will. The Suthmark loves him the way a province loves a boy it expects to bury — completely, and without respect. Speech pattern: quiet, exact, faintly amused; asks the second question rather than the first.

Tavian is younger by four years, healthy, well-liked by precisely the wrong people, and entirely aware that the Denmother's Choice is revisable — that an heir is named by open declaration, and can be named again. He is not plotting against his brother. He is waiting, which is worse, because waiting asks nothing of him he would ever have to confess. Speech pattern: warm, generous, agrees early and often; the only man in the south who never mentions his brother's health.

DM Only: the succession is the Suthmark's fault line, and it runs directly beneath the Vintage Night. Emerenn governs on her sons' sufferance and everyone politely pretends otherwise; if the Garland lady's cipher-diary ever surfaces, the question of who actually rules the south becomes urgent in the same hour it becomes public. Neither son knows what their mother ordered that night. One of them has stopped asking.

COUNTESS VELSANNA ORY OF GREYWELL

Historical key: Elizabeth Báthory. The Ory family has held the grey hill country of the eastern Suthmark for four hundred years, and Castle Greywell has always been the kind of place the valley folk are relieved not to be invited to. Countess Velsanna is the last of the main line: a widow of vast estates and vaster loans — the crown itself owes the Ory treasury sums it has no intention of repaying — famously charitable at a distance, famously beautiful in a way that does not change. Her age is a local superstition: church records make her seventy; travelers who glimpse her at her gates describe a woman of forty. Servant girls take the good wages at Greywell and, some seasons, do not come home. The families are paid grief-silver. The local priest writes letters that are never answered. Nobody with power has ever had a reason to look, and everyone without power has excellent reasons not to. Speech pattern: gracious, old-fashioned, faintly amused, with the unhurried attention of something that has never once needed to rush.

Threads: Greywell is the campaign's pure gothic horror — deliberately unconnected to the shadow, because a living world grows its own evils, and the party should not be able to assume every darkness is the metaplot. **DM Only:** the horror is real. Velsanna sustains her youth by old blood-rite sorcery [mechanism to be detailed if she enters play — a hag-bargain, a fiendish compact, and an inherited rite are all viable; choose when needed], and the count of the missing runs past forty girls across two decades. The bitter irony preserved from history: when power finally moves against her, it will move for the debts, not the dead — and the party may be the only force in the world that ever comes for the girls' sake. As a villain she is beatable at almost any tier; as an institution — the silence, the grief-silver, the unanswered letters — she is a preview of every fight the campaign will ever pose.

SAINT-REGENT OLVEA THE RECONCILED — FOUNDER OF THE SEE OF ORLATH

Historical key: Olga of Kiev. Sixty years ago she was the young widow-regent of a northern principality whose lord had been murdered under guest-right by the Drevec clan-lords — and what she did about it is still told in the north in four movements, each worse than the last: the envoys buried alive with their gifts; the lodge burned with the second delegation feasting inside it; the funeral-feast on her husband's barrow where three hundred Drevec notables drank themselves helpless among her soldiers; and the birds

— the tribute of sparrows and doves from every Drevic roof, released home at dusk with fire tied to their feet. Then, with her vengeance complete and her name a horror, she walked into a mountain shrine of the Matron and did not come out for a year. What came out was the woman the north now calls the Reconciled — and the See of Orlath founded itself around her rather than by her, penitents and clergy-refugees gathering to the shrine faster than she could send them home. She is its founder the way bedrock founds a house: she never set out to build a church, and the church was simply what would not leave. She set down her sword and her armor in the same season she gave up the Drevic tongue, and has taken up none of the three since — architect of the See's plain and rigorous rite almost against her will, and the nearest thing the fractured world has to a living saint, a title she accepts with visible distaste because she alone keeps the full ledger of what it cost. Her other title is stranger and more precise. The See holds the Lupine Throne vacant and its emperor illegitimate, and has done since its founding — which leaves a seat that must be kept by someone until it can be lawfully filled. Olvesa is Saint-Regent because she keeps it: regent of the True Rite, placeholder for an emperor not yet crowned, for sixty years. She rejects the capital Church not from doctrine first but from knowledge: she has seen, from the inside, exactly what absolution in the service of power looks like. Speech pattern: plain, spare, scripture-cadenced; never euphemizes her own past — refers to the four vengeance as “my instruction,” meaning what taught her.

Threads: Olvesa is the campaign's test of whether redemption is real — a genuinely holy woman with a river of blood behind her, leading a genuinely purer church toward a genuinely catastrophic act. **DM Only:** her visions are true. Fragments of the storm and the wrong fire have reached her for decades, and three years ago — the season Nyreeza vanished — they darkened sharply. She reads them as the Matron's verdict on the corrupt capital and its oath-broken throne, and it is this conviction, not ambition, that has moved the coronation of her grandson from someday to now. She is, in perfect sincerity, about to crown a rival emperor because the shadow's stirring told her to. If anyone could ever show her what the visions actually are, the entire northern crisis would turn on that conversation. Note also what the coronation costs her personally: the moment Karvel is crowned, the regency she has held for sixty years dissolves, its purpose discharged. She has been keeping a chair warm for the grandson she is about to seat in it, and she knows it. Play her as a woman completing her life's work, not as one grasping at a new one.

KING KARVEL OF ARDVEN — THE UNCROWNED EMPEROR OF THE NORTH

Historical key: Charlemagne. Grandson of Saint-Regent Olvesa, king of a realm he assembled himself: fifteen years of war, marriage, and administration that turned a dozen northern crowns and clan-lands into Ardden. Karvel is broad, loud, semi-lettered and obsessed with letters — he reads slowly and has founded forty monastery schools; he sleeps four hours and audits his reeves personally; he prays like a soldier and legislates like a clerk. He is, in every way the capital would find uncomfortable to admit, what Qilvayas is trying to become: a unifier whose restoration is actually working. And this coming Solacre, if nothing intervenes, his grandmother's church will crown him Emperor of the True Rite — a second empire, sanctified by a second church, in direct and explicit denial of the Lupine Throne's mandate. Karvel himself is ambivalent in private: he wants the crown's

legitimacy for his heirs, distrusts the theology, and suspects — correctly — that the coronation makes eventual war with the south very hard to avoid. Speech pattern: booming, blunt, unexpectedly precise on numbers; quotes scripture slightly wrong and dares anyone to correct him.

Threads: the coronation is the campaign's second structural clock, set for the same year as the Zhuvedian Laws' promulgation — two rival covenants, sworn at opposite ends of the world, in the same season [**DM note:** the collision of these clocks is deliberate; whatever else the mid-campaign holds, that year should feel like a hinge of history]. Karvel is not a villain: he is a good king building a rival answer to the same question Qilvayas is asking, and the party may find his answer persuasive. **DM Only:** a coronation is an oath sworn before a god — and the entity beneath Aenodira, born from a broken covenant at an empire's founding, will be listening with two thousand years of attention when a new empire swears its founding covenant. What that means in practice is deliberately open: design the consequence when the campaign approaches it.

DUKE GARVIN NORR — THE BASTARD OF NORMERE

Historical key: William the Conqueror. Baseborn son of the old Duke of Normere, acknowledged but never legitimized, who survived three assassination attempts before the age of twenty, killed the last of his trueborn rivals in the field at twenty-four, and has spent the two decades since building the most ruthlessly administered state west of Aenodira. Norr's conquest of the Brekelands proceeds warlord by warlord, and it is not pillage — it is absorption: every conquered holding is surveyed into the Reckoning Book, every landholder swears the personal oath to Norr himself over the heads of all intermediate lords, and every sworn man's obligations, taxes, and levies are recorded, audited, and enforced. Where submission is offered, terms are kept to the letter. Where it is refused — the Harrowing of the Weld, four years ago, ended a district's rebellion by ending, for a generation, the district. He claims descent from an old imperial governor's line and styles his conquest “the restoration of lawful administration,” which has the special insolence of being partly true. Speech pattern: flat, economical, deliberately unceremonious; recites exact figures from memory as intimidation; the word “bastard” goes unremarked in his presence exactly once.

Threads: Norr is Qilvayas's dark mirror — restoration by conquest and ledger against restoration by law and consent — and the empire's most dangerous rival precisely because his subjects' lives measurably improve. His westward absorption of the Brekelands is on a collision course with Ban Dregan's Eastmarch, and what happens when the Reckoning Book meets the Fence is one of the campaign's promised storms. **DM Only:** the personal oaths are the detail that matters. Norr has bound tens of thousands of souls to himself by sworn word — the largest concentration of living oaths in the fractured world — and he keeps his side of every one of them, scrupulously, as policy. He has, without knowing it, built either the shadow's greatest feast (if he ever breaks faith at scale) or the strongest oath-bound bulwark on the continent (if he never does). A single great betrayal by Norr would feed the entity beyond anything since the fracture began. He must never learn that. Certain other parties, late in the campaign, might try to arrange it.

GEOGRAPHY AND LOCATIONS

AENODIRA: THE IMPERIAL CAPITAL

Aenodira sits where the Ostrun bends into a wide horseshoe against its northern approach, and the city has grown, ring by ring, to fill everything the river's curve allows and then some. Three walls circle it, each raised in a different age of the empire and each still wearing the color of the age that built it: the Founder's Wall, innermost and oldest, dark and roughly hewn; the High Wall, pale gold limestone raised at the height of imperial wealth, wide-gated and half ceremonial; and the Long Wall, outermost, red brick thrown up fast during the empire's last great expansion — the one that came right before the fracture began. Walking outward from the palace is walking forward through two thousand years of the empire's confidence, ring by ring, until you reach the wall it built for a city that never came.

Aenodira is inland, definitively: well up the Ostrun's valley, with river trade through Rivergate but no ocean harbor of any kind — the nearest salt water is Velmareth's delta, ten days downriver. Every approach is therefore a road or the river, and which one shapes a traveler before they ever see the walls: four days from the Ostmark through loyalist country that still mostly functions; two weeks from the Brekelands, where banditry is the ambient condition rather than the exception; three weeks down from Tarnovar's highlands, where the Fence's deterrence ends at Fencegate and does not follow you into the Crownlands; or up the Ostrun itself from Velmareth — river traffic with a different flavor of risk entirely, tolls and smugglers and whatever operates out of Rivergate's quieter berths, rather than anything so honest as highway robbery.

The Long Wall was built on the assumption that the city would keep growing to fill it. It didn't. The result is an outer city that is unevenly occupied — half-finished districts standing empty beside others crammed well past any sensible density — and that unevenness, more than any single landmark, is what the outer ring is actually about.

THE INNER CITY

Contained within the Founder's Wall, the oldest heart of Aenodira is where the empire's two great authorities face each other across a shallow valley: the palace on one rise, the Temple on the other, close enough that a bell rung in one is heard clearly in the other — which everyone who has ever needed to negotiate between throne and altar has found either convenient or ominous, depending on which side of the negotiation they were on.

HIGHCOURT

The palace district, called Highcourt by everyone except the clerks who insist on "the Palatine Precinct" in official correspondence, holds the Lupine Throne, the ministries that keep what remains of the empire's paperwork running, and the townhouses of whatever nobility still bothers to maintain a capital residence. It is guarded, aloof, and quieter than a city this size has any right to be at its literal center — quiet in the particular way of a place where everyone is watching everyone else's movements and nobody wants to be the one who made noise.

The Long Course, a broad ceremonial avenue and parade ground running along Highcourt's eastern edge, is where the legions march on imperial holidays, where new laws are read aloud to whatever public gathers to hear them, and where the proclamations of the coming Zhuvedian Laws are currently posted at every crossing. It is also, not incidentally, the traditional site of public executions, though the current reign has used it for that purpose only twice.

Power and Presence: Access to the Emperor himself runs through Lord Chamberlain Vareth Kessin, a career bureaucrat who has outlasted two regents and one attempted reform of his own office, and who treats every petitioner's business as simultaneously vital and faintly beneath him. Nothing reaches Qilvayas without passing Kessin's desk first, which makes Kessin one of the most quietly powerful people in the empire and one of the least visible.

THE SANCTUM

Across the valley from Highcourt, the Sanctum climbs the second of the city's two hills toward the golden dome of the Great Temple of the Matron — visible, on a clear day, from every ring of the city and from the pilgrim road for a day's travel before arrival. Beneath and around the Temple proper spreads the Church's actual machinery: administrative halls, seminaries, the residences of a clergy that ranges from genuinely devout to comfortably political, and the Office of Omens, whose officials would very much like to be the empire's sole authority on visions, portents, and divine will, and who resent, with real institutional bitterness, that they are not.

Power and Presence: Matriarch Ilsevet Corvane, Voice of the Matron in the capital, is the Church's most senior public figure in Aenodira — not its supreme authority (that distinction is more contested, and more interesting, than any single title suggests), but its face, its administrator, and the person any official inquiry into the party's shared vision would eventually land on. She is neither villain nor ally by default; she is institution, and institutions protect themselves first and ask questions about truth second. The Office of Omens answers to her, nominally.

THE OLD FORUM

Tucked against the inside of the Founder's Wall, in the oldest and least renovated corner of the Inner City, the Old Forum is what remains of Aenodira before it was a capital — a warren of foundation-stones, half-buried columns, and one weathered monument to Zhuvedus himself, worn smooth by two thousand years of hands touching it for luck on the way to somewhere else. Scholars catalogue it. Beggars and the genuinely destitute shelter in it. Nobody has excavated it properly in living memory, because proper excavation would mean admitting how little the Church and the imperial cult actually agree on what they'd find there.

DM Only: Confirmed canon: the binding site lies beneath the Old Forum's foundations, reached through the catacombs that everyone knows exist and nobody has fully mapped, descending into the Undercourt's deepest reach. All future site design builds on this as fixed ground.

THE UNDERCOURT (DM ONLY)

Aenodira stands on Aenodira. Beneath the modern city lies a connected pre-imperial stratum — the Undercourt — the buried remains of whatever stood here before Zhuvedus's

founding: black roughly-hewn stone of the same make as the Founder's Wall, streets three man-heights below the current ones, and chambers that predate every map the empire keeps. The catacombs under the Old Forum touch it. So, in places, do the deep vaults under Scholar's Row — including the academy's decommissioned Undervault, which matters in Sessions Three and Four. The Church has never excavated it; the imperial cult has never asked to; both institutions' disinterest is older than anyone can account for and functions, in practice, like a door everyone has agreed not to try.

In the Undercourt's deepest reach lies the binding site — the place the oath was broken and Threnvos died. The descent as far as the Second Seal is now built and canon (see Session Six); what lies beyond the Seal remains the next major build. Established features: cold that deepens with proximity (the same cold as Dren's medallion); pre-imperial inscriptions in a script the Church does not teach; and evidence, in at least two places, of a careful modern visitor — hairline survey marks in Empress Nyreeza's personal cipher, three years old. She found a way down. Whether she found a way back up is the campaign's open wound.

THE MIDDLE CITY

Beyond the High Wall, Aenodira does its actual work. This is where most of the city's population lives, trades, studies, and prays without any particular proximity to power — and where the party will spend most of their time in the capital.

COPPERGATE

Already familiar to the party by the time they reach it: copyists, instrument-makers, retired functionaries, laundry strung between balconies, and, above a copyist's shop on Ninth Lane, the blue-shuttered apartment of Vaelindra of the Still Waters. Coppergate is comfortable, unglamorous, and exactly the kind of place someone chooses when they want to be findable only by people who already know where to look.

SCHOLAR'S ROW

Home to the Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne — swept courts, ringing bells, restricted archives kept by Archivist Dathenor Vell — along with the smaller tutoring houses, instrument shops, and cheap lodging-houses that cluster around any institution full of young people with stipends. The party's dormitory years live here. So, less pleasantly, does the reputation the academy has spent decades trying to shed: everyone in Scholar's Row has an opinion about which students are lottery winners and which are hostages, and most of those opinions are wrong in interesting ways.

THE EXCHANGE

Aenodira's guildhalls, counting-houses, and covered markets, where what remains of the empire's trade actually changes hands. Merchant Republic delegations keep permanent offices here — officially trade missions, unofficially outposts of exactly the disorder-preferring interests already described under the empire's current political landscape.

Power and Presence: Guildmaster Ptolan Vess, head of the Capital Merchants' Concord, is the closest thing the Exchange has to a single voice, though "closest thing" undersells how little the guilds actually agree with each

other. Vess is pragmatic, genuinely apolitical by temperament, and privately convinced that Qilvayas's restoration project is bad for business regardless of whether it succeeds.

THE GARRISON

Barracks, drill yards, and the administrative offices of whatever legion elements are currently garrisoned in the capital — a smaller and more ceremonial presence than the empire once kept here, which everyone in the Garrison is uncomfortably aware of.

Power and Presence: Legate Bruvasca Thorne commands the Palatine Guard, the capital's actual defensive force, and maintains a professional, faintly weary correspondence with provincial magistrates — including, as it happens, Cassivar Ondrei of Dravenna, whose complaint against the Third Legion's colonel is currently sitting somewhere in Thorne's inbox, exactly as slow-moving as every other piece of institutional accountability in the empire.

THE OUTER CITY

THE ARCHWORK

An old imperial aqueduct crosses the outer city on a run of high stone arches, most of it still functional, several sections long since bricked up and converted into multi-story housing wedged directly into the arch spans. Rent is cheap because the housing is, structurally speaking, a repurposed water pipe, and everyone who lives there knows it. Nickname aside, the Archwork is a working-class district in the ordinary sense — laborers, small tradespeople, the families of Garrison rank-and-file who can't afford anything closer to the center.

FARROWGATE

The newest and least planned district in the city, growing without much municipal help along the Long Wall's inner face, populated overwhelmingly by displaced people from the fractured territories — not any single group, but a slow accretion of every border skirmish, warlord dispute, and burned village that has sent someone walking toward the capital because an old story said the throne feeds its own. Established Aenodirans call it Farrowgate without much affection; the people who live there increasingly use the name themselves, the way a slur gets worn down into an identity by people who didn't get to choose it.

This is not where Semya's people from Halvenne ended up, if the party helped resettle them in Dravenna — but it is exactly where they would have ended up if the party hadn't.

RIVERGATE

The docks and river trade quarter, where goods — and a fair amount that isn't quite goods — move in and out of the capital. Less prestigious than the Exchange, less regulated, and considerably more interesting to anyone investigating something the empire's official record doesn't want to explain, including, plausibly, wherever Odric Hale bought his dead Roads Commission seal.

None of this is exhaustive, and it isn't meant to be — Aenodira should grow the way real capitals do, one specific street or shopfront named the moment a scene actually needs it, built outward from this framework rather than pre-mapped down to the alley. What's fixed for now: the three rings and their walls, the two hills of Highcourt and the

Sanctum, Coppergate's location relative to the Academy, and the Old Forum as the confirmed location above the binding site (**DM only**).

Whatever lies beneath the capital — the likely site of the broken oath and Threnvos's death (see The Founding Myth: Zhuvodus and the Broken Oath) — should be developed alongside the capital itself, since the two are now the same design problem.

PLOT HOOKS AND ADVENTURE SEEDS

Seeds already planted by Sessions Zero through Four, ready to grow when the table needs them. Each is deliberately small enough to run as a side thread and connected enough to pay into the main arc.

The Colonel's Reckoning: Ondrei's complaint against Colonel Aurel Dessen of the Third Legion grinds through Legate Thorne's office. The colonel has friends, the surviving deserters' testimony needs protecting, and the party is the reason there is a case at all. A courtroom-and-intimidation arc in the Ostmark — and a test of whether the system Qilvayas is rebuilding can actually convict one of its own.

The Seal Dealer of Rivergate (engaged: Session Five): Odric Hale's dead Roads Commission seal came from somewhere. The dealer trades in the seals, signets, and letterheads of abolished imperial offices — and someone has recently bought the seals of offices that handled the old censuses of the Founder's Wall district. Who wants to forge authority over the oldest records in the city, and why now?

Forty Witnesses: Semya's people, resettled in Dravenna (or struggling in Farrowgate if not), become a listening post and a responsibility. When trouble reaches them — a landlord, a press-gang, a recruiter for someone's private army — the party learns what their earlier kindness actually bought, and what it obligates.

The Office of Omens Moves (engaged: Sessions Five–Six): Prelate Odell's office hears of a full academy cohort, a shared dream, and an unsanctioned consultation in Coppergate — and under its new posture, it does not merely open a file. Surveillance, a summons with teeth, and ultimately a Writ of Examination against Vaelindra herself. The courtesy remains; the patience does not. How the party handles being hunted by paperwork shapes their standing with the Church for the entire campaign.

The Cold Door (engaged: Session Six): The unscripted door in the Undervault (Sessions Three and Four) does not go away. Masons re-seal the wing; the party holds a rubbing of cipher marks Vell can identify as the Empress's hand. The first thread of the Nyreeza trail, and the campaign's standing invitation to go beneath the city.

A Clerk from Highcourt (engaged: Session Five): Someone from Chamberlain Kessin's office observed the Proving. The newly chartered company receives its first real commission — modest, deniable, and a test with the throne's fingerprints kept carefully off it. Passing it opens the palace door an inch.

The Tarnovar Envoy: A rare Tarnovari delegation comes to Aenodira — trade terms, nominally — and its members unsettle everyone: they will not swear on the Matron, they touch stone before signing anything, and one of their singers performs a ballad of Vosthren the Betrayed within earshot of the wrong scholar. A slow fuse to the campaign's largest buried revelation.

The Medallion Grows Colder: Dren's defaced oath-medallion is a barometer nobody knows how to read yet. Days when it is colder correlate — the party will eventually notice — with news of some notable broken faith somewhere in the fracturing empire. A quiet, persistent instrument for seeding the central mechanism without a word of exposition.

The Landless King's Fifth Petition: Sea-King Aldrec sends envoys to Aenodira one more time — tally-sticks, formal Imperial, and an offer to hold the coast against his own displaced kin in exchange for a march and a title. The court means to refuse him again. Anyone — the party included — who grasps what is actually being offered has a narrow window to change the answer before the window closes with Aldrec's failing health.

Solacre Day: The promulgation isn't three developments that happen to share a season — it's one convergent day. Qilvayas reads the Zhuvedian Laws aloud from the Long Course as scheduled; Book One's language on the Marked lands in that same reading, whichever way the party tipped it; Book Three's registration requirement, newly extended over Long Course commerce, takes effect in front of the crowd it affects most (see The Grey-Gold Rising, below); and within the same day, word reaches the capital that Karvel has been crowned in Orlath (see The Coronation Clock, below). Three structural clocks, one bell.

The Grey-Gold Rising: The spark isn't a new tax — it's Book Three's existing mark-and-register requirement, extended for the first time over Long Course commerce: stables, trainers, tipsters, and bookmakers now need a Crown-guild register entry like any other mundane trade, with the same burden-shifting teeth as everywhere else. The Golds — the inner-wall houses, patron money and breeding stock — resent an inspector auditing what used to run on handshake and patronage. The Greys — the outer-wall trade, concession workers and small bookmakers who've never registered anything with anyone — are the ones actually hauled before a magistrate for lacking an entry they never knew to make. It takes one well-liked name made an example of at the Course itself before two factions who've hated each other for generations discover they hate this more. What follows is a capital riot in the Justinianic mold: the day Qilvayas must choose between mercy and massacre, with the party positioned wherever their choices have put them. **DM Only:** deliberately live, tracked on the Branch Ledger exactly like the Marked's personhood — what the party has actually built by the time it breaks (Thorne's room to maneuver, how much warning Qilvayas gets, who's physically present and what they do) tips it either way. A massacre feeds the thing beneath the city at real scale; a mercied Rising is the Laws doing, for the first time in public, the one thing they were built to do. Don't manufacture the spark before the party's choices have given it a direction to fall.

The Coronation Clock: Orlath crowns King Karvel Emperor of the True Rite this coming Solacre — the same day, not merely the same season, as the Laws' promulgation (see Solacre Day, above). Two rival covenants, sworn at opposite ends of the world, arriving in the capital's ears within the same hour. Embassies, sabotage, desperate diplomacy, and the question nobody in the capital is asking: why now? (The DM knows: Olvesa's visions darkened three years ago. See The Powers of the Fractured Empire.)

The Girls of Greywell: A Farrowgate family begs the newly chartered company to find a daughter who took service in the Suthmark hills and stopped writing. The trail leads to Castle Greywell, grief-silver, unanswered letters — and a horror with four hundred years of rank and no connection at all to the shadow. Some evils are just evils. The party may be the first force that ever comes for the girls' sake.

The Book and the Fence: Norr’s surveyors reach the eastern Brekeland hills within sight of Ban Dregan’s stakes. Two absolute systems of order regard each other across a valley. Whoever is standing between them — refugees, merchants, a party on a job — gets to watch history decide whether the Reckoning Book and the Fence can share a border.

THE IMPERIAL CALENDAR

Twelve months, opening at the year’s turn in deep winter with the Matron’s own liturgical season, running the plain agricultural cycle everyone actually lives by, and closing with her second high month before the year turns again.

Month	Season	Character
Wolfmoon	Deep winter (year begins)	The Matron’s high liturgical month; the year turns in her keeping, not the sun’s.
Thawtide	Late winter	Roads reopen; the Ostmark’s watch-forts change garrison.
Sowmonth	Early spring	Suthmark planting begins; the year’s first oaths of service are traditionally sworn.
Greening	Mid-spring	Long Course racing season opens (Golds vs. Greys).
Solacre	Early summer	Court business in full swing; the Zhuvedian Laws are slated for a Solacre reading.
Haymonth	Midsummer	Rural labor peak; Academy field exercises traditionally run Hay-Harvestide.
Harvestide	Early autumn	The Suthmark’s great harvest festival — and the Vintage Night fell in Harvestide.
Vinmoon	Mid-autumn	Grape harvest; Suthmark vintages are dated by Vinmoon year.
Fallowmonth	Late autumn	Fields rest; Suthmark inheritance customarily settles at Fallowmonth’s turn.
Greywane	Early winter	Days shorten; the Long Course racing season closes.
Longdark	Deep winter	The Matron’s second high month, mirroring Wolfmoon; Vigil Halls keep continuous watch.
Threshold	Year’s end	A short, liminal month of 20 days — old debts settled, old oaths renewed, before Wolfmoon turns the year.

Loyalist territory counts Years of the Reckoning (YR) from the Founding, the exact figure left deliberately soft. Orlath keeps YR for trade and secular record-keeping but privately dates its liturgical documents from the Reconciliation, Olvesa’s year in the shrine — even the schismatics haven’t stopped using the empire’s clock, they’ve simply started keeping a second one. Tarnovar mostly dispenses with numbered years for internal purposes, marking time by successive Voivodes’ reigns instead. A light seven-day week — a market day, a rest day tied to Vigil-keeping, five working

days — completes the structure without inventing texture nobody will use at the table.

CAMPAIGN TIMELINE AND PACING

Chronology of established events, relative to the campaign’s present day (the party’s final field exercise, six weeks before commencement). Dates are framed as “years ago” to stay portable if a calendar is adopted later.

~2,000 years ago: The founding. Zhuvedus breaks the sworn covenant, destroys Threnvos, and establishes the empire alone. The binding site seals whatever remained. Threnvos’s surviving people scatter west; their descendants become Tarnovar.

~200 years ago: The fracture begins. Provinces fall away over the following two centuries; every abandoned fealty and torn treaty feeds what waits beneath the capital.

Across the two centuries since: The throne turns inward as the provinces turn away. The Lupine Throne changes hands far faster than a Drow line should — reigns cut short by fever, by faction, by an unlucky border or a fall on the Long Course, twice falling to child-heirs and the regents who ruled in their place. The court names a cause for each and never counts them together. Nyreeza, ruling in her own right until a son grown enough to follow her without a regent, is the first steadiness the throne has known in longer than most can remember. (See the Packlaw; and DM Only, The Scouring.)

~60 years ago: The Silvasse Disaster: three legions and their wolf-standards lost in the western woods — the fracture’s military nadir, and the wound Marshal Dane’s recovery of the Ninth’s standard has begun, sixty years on, to heal.

~60–58 years ago: In the north: the murder of Olvesa’s lord under guest-right, her four vengeance against the Drevic clans, her year in the mountain shrine, and the See of Orlath founding itself around her on her return (~58 years ago).

~50 years ago: Vaelindra’s career-ending vision — fragments of the true founding — and her quiet removal from the Church. She begins her independent ledger of visions.

~40 years ago: A young Dregan Morn arrives at the capital academy as a hostage-student of Tarnovar, and stays on past his studies, as hostages do, at the throne’s convenience; he returns home a decade later, changed.

~20 years ago: The Weeping Strait: an imperial admiral spends three thousand Skell auxiliaries to save his squadrons. Aldrec survives, is denied his promised command, and begins his kingship of the displaced. In the west, Garvin Norr kills the last of his trueborn rivals and takes Normere in fact.

~15 years ago: Karvel begins the consolidation of the northern crowns into Ardden; the ship-clans lose their fjords over the following years and turn south.

~12 years ago: Empress Nyreeza begins the academy revival and the first institutional reforms — and, somewhere in these years, her private inquiry into the founding.

11 years ago: Archivist Vell’s last referral to Vaelindra — the one that ended badly. He has not presumed on her since.

6 years ago: The Vintage Night: Orlathine congregations massacred in three Suthmark towns during the harvest

festival. Duchess Vasq owns an order she may not have meant. The south learns to fear her.

4 years ago: The Harrowing of the Weld: Duke Norr ends a district’s rebellion, and the district, for a generation. The west learns what his patience costs.

3 years ago: Nyreeza’s final meeting with Vaelindra; her disappearance shortly after. Vaelindra’s ledger records the vision-fragments accelerating from this season — and, unknown to the capital, Saint-Regent Olvesa’s visions darken the same season, setting the coronation in motion. A six-month search and interregnum follows.

~3 years ago (DM only): In the western wood, Vessarkath lets one wolf-standard leave her hoard — she felt the stir beneath the capital (see The Acceleration); through the Brekelands warlords, the Ninth’s eagle begins its slow way home.

~2.5 years ago: Qilvayas’s coronation. The restoration project begins in earnest: the Law Commission under Archjurist Vhal, the academy expansion, the diplomatic overtures.

~1 year ago: Marshal Dane recovers the Ninth’s standard from the Brekelands, nearly sixty years after Silvasse swallowed it. The Ostmark’s deepest wound begins to close, and the empire gets its Young Wolf.

This coming Solacre, nine months out: Two clocks, one day: the Zhuvedian Laws promulgated from the Long Course — Book One’s language on the Marked inside that same reading, and Book Three’s registration falling on Long Course commerce in front of the crowd it costs most — and, within the same hours, word from Orlath that Karvel has been crowned Emperor of the True Rite. Rival covenants at opposite ends of the world, arriving in the capital’s ears on one bell: the restoration’s point of no return, and its first true rival. Every faction in the empire is already positioning.

Present day: The party’s field exercise, the vision, the return to Aenodira, and the Proving. Commencement — moved up for the Proven cohort — follows Session Four.

Pacing guidance: the Zhuvedian Laws promulgation is the campaign’s first structural clock — events the party does not attend to will still move toward it. The three-year freshness of Nyreeza’s disappearance means her trail is warm: witnesses remember, her cipher marks are recent, and her son’s grief is a live political fact rather than settled history. Vaelindra’s correlation — the visions accelerating from the season the Empress vanished — is the connective tissue the party can discover early, and it is true: whatever Nyreeza did at the binding site changed something.

APPENDIX I — THE ROSTER: RACES AND CLASSES

Class entries are archetype keys for flavor and improvisation — NPC stat blocks remain custom-built per DMG practice, not class-leveled builds. ‘Statted’ marks the ten who receive full blocks in Part IV.

Name	Race	Class / Archetype	Standing
Emperor Qilvayas	Drow	Paladin (Crown-sworn)	CR 9 (statted)

Name	Race	Class / Archetype	Standing
Legate Bruvasca Thorne	Human	Fighter (Battle Master)	CR 10 (statted)
Marshal Gavric Dane	Human	Fighter (Champion, leader)	CR 7 (statted)
Ban Dregan Morn	Human	Paladin (Oath of Vengeance)	CR 9 (statted)
Sea-King Aldrec	Human	Fighter (raider-king)	CR 7 (statted)
Duke Garvin Norr	Human	Fighter (mastermind)	CR 8 (statted)
King Karvel	Human	Fighter (Champion, crowned)	CR 8 (statted)
Saint-Regent Olvesa	Human	Cleric (Life, true visions)	CR 10 (statted)
Mistress Averil Shen	Human	Rogue (Mastermind)	CR 6 (statted)
Prelate Sarvin Odell	Human	Cleric (Knowledge)	CR 5 (statted)
Empress Nyreeza (absent)	Drow	Wizard (scholar-sovereign)	Fate open, by design
Vaelindra of the Still Waters	Human	Seer (no class; true visions)	No stats, by design
Duchess Emerenn Vasq	Human	Noble (Mastermind; the Garland)	Social CR 4 — Social block later
Countess Velsanna Ory	Human	Blood-rite sorceress	Deferred — Greywell module
Voivode Ysavet Morn	Human	Noble (elder stateswoman)	Social
Lord Chamberlain Kessin	Human	Noble (gatekeeper)	Social
Archjurist Senna Vhal	Half-elf	Expert (jurist)	Social
Hierophant Malzeth Corr	Human	Cleric (imperial cult)	CR 3-equiv
Matriarch Ilsevet Corvane	Human	Cleric (institutional)	CR 7-equiv
Archivist Dathenor Vell	Hill dwarf	Sage (archivist)	No stats
Professor Corvin Dail	Human	Fighter (drillmaster)	CR 5-equiv
Chancellor Emeth Sorral	Half-elf (canon)	Noble (mage-lite)	Social
Instructor Liria Fenn	Human	Bard (College of Lore)	CR 4-equiv
Magistrate Cassivar Ondrei	Human	Noble/Expert (magistrate)	Social

Name	Race	Class / Archetype	Standing
Sgt. Petra Malich	Human	Fighter (soldier)	CR 1 (statted, S2) — Existing
Odric Hale	Human	Rogue (charlatan)	CR 1/2 (statted, S2) — Existing
Clerk Ossian Pell	Human	Commoner (clerk)	No
Tirell Mosse	Rock gnome	Expert (dealer)	No
Brune Halloc	Half-orc	Fighter (dock boss)	CR 2 (statted, S5) — Existing
The Widow Brakka	Hill dwarf	Commoner (landlady, undefeated)	Beyond CR
Censor-Captain Ferrin Odo	Human	Fighter (church soldier)	CR 3 (statted, S6) — Existing
Ilinca Verath	Tarnovari human	Bard (ballad-keeper)	No
Warlords Skarn & Voss	Human	Fighters (veterans)	CR 3–4-equiv
Colonel Aurel Dessen	Human	Fighter (corrupt officer)	CR 3-equiv
Duke Aldous Vasq	Human	Noble (invalid administrator)	No stats
Tavian Vasq	Human	Noble (heir in waiting)	Social
Marshal Dane's analog gap — Yanna, Semya, Vorn, Tobble, Bram	Human	Commoners / Nobles	No

APPENDIX II — STAT BLOCKS OF THE POWERS

Custom NPC blocks keyed to class archetypes, validated against the DMG Monster Statistics by Challenge Rating table and SRD analogs (validation summary at section end). Design intent: these are human legends, not demigods — the CR 6–10 band means a mid-campaign party could theoretically fight any of them, which is exactly the right scale; their true power is armies, institutions, and oaths, not hit points.

Emperor Qilvayas

Medium humanoid (Drow), lawful neutral — Paladin (Crown-sworn)

Armor Class: 18 (ceremonial plate under robes of state)

Hit Points: 123 (19d8 + 38)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	17 (+3)	15 (+2)	18 (+4)

Saving Throws: Wis +6, Cha +8

Skills: History +7, Insight +6, Persuasion +8, Religion +7

Senses: darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 12

Languages: Common, Old Imperial, Elvish, three provincial tongues

Challenge: 9 (5,000 XP)

The Crown Oath. Qilvayas is sworn to the empire itself, and the Matron answers: his paladin gifts function. (DM only: that his oath holds — that the goddess still answers the dynasty of the Oathbreaker — is itself a theological fact of enormous, unexamined weight.)

Aura of the Throne. Allies within 10 feet of Qilvayas can't be frightened and add +2 to saving throws while he is conscious.

The Founder's Mercy. Qilvayas carries a healing pool of 45 hit points (as Lay on Hands). He spends it on others. Always on others.

Spellcasting. Half-caster (spell save DC 16): command, zone of truth, dispel magic, and — once per day — a divination that he has never cast, because he is afraid of the answer.

Fey Ancestry / Sunlight Sensitivity (adapted). Advantage vs. charm; immune to magical sleep. The Founder's Blood has long since adapted to the sun — no sensitivity — but the dynasty's great liturgies are sung at night, and he is, visibly, most himself after dark.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Qilvayas makes two attacks with Vigil, the dynastic longsword.

Vigil (Longsword). Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d8 + 4) slashing damage plus 9 (2d8) radiant damage — the Founder's light, which the court has not seen him draw in anger, ever.

REACTIONS

Sovereign's Interposition. When a creature within 5 feet of Qilvayas is hit by an attack, he can make himself the target instead. His guards hate this. He does it anyway.

Legate Bruvasca Thorne

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral — Fighter (Battle Master)

Armor Class: 18 (plate)

Hit Points: 143 (22d8 + 44)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws: Str +9, Con +6

Skills: Athletics +9, History +7, Insight +6, Perception +6

Senses: passive Perception 16

Languages: Common, Old Imperial, Skell

Challenge: 10 (5,900 XP)

Ashline Discipline. Allied creatures within 30 feet of Thorne can't be surprised, and gain +10 feet of speed when moving toward a position she designates (free, once per round).

Indomitable (2/Day). Thorne can reroll a failed saving throw.

Superiority (5d10/rest). Maneuver dice fueling her Riposte, Trip, and Rally (grant an ally 15 temporary hit points) — spend as the fiction demands.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Thorne makes three longsword attacks.

Longsword (two-handed). Melee Weapon Attack: +9 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 12 (2d6 + 5) slashing damage. On a Trip maneuver, add 1d10 and the target saves (Str DC 17) or falls prone.

REACTIONS

Riposte. When a creature misses Thorne with a melee attack, she spends a superiority die and attacks it: +9 to hit, 12 (2d6 + 5) + 5 (1d10) slashing.

Marshal Gavric Dane, the Young Wolf

Medium humanoid (human), lawful good — Fighter (Champion, leader)

Armor Class: 18 (plate)

Hit Points: 110 (17d8 + 34)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)	13 (+1)	15 (+2)	18 (+4)

Saving Throws: Str +7, Con +5

Skills: Animal Handling +5, Athletics +7, Persuasion +7

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Common, Old Imperial

Challenge: 7 (2,900 XP)

The Standard Holds. Allies within 30 feet who can see Dane have advantage on saving throws against being frightened and add +1 to attack rolls. If Dane falls, every ally who saw it makes a DC 15 Wisdom save or is frightened 1 round — and then gains his +1 permanently for the battle. (The legions would burn the world for him. That is the problem.)

For the Ninth! (Recharge 5–6). Dane makes three additional longsword attacks, split among targets, and allies within 30 feet may each use their reaction to move 10 feet.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Dane makes three longsword attacks.

Longsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (1d10 + 4) slashing damage (versatile, two-handed). Critical on 19–20.

Ban Dregan Morn, Lord of the Fence

Medium humanoid (human, Tarnovari), lawful neutral (evil methods) — Paladin (Oath of Vengeance)

Armor Class: 17 (splint, meticulous)

Hit Points: 130 (20d8 + 40)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)	16 (+3)	16 (+3)

Saving Throws: Wis +7, Cha +7

Skills: Insight +7, Intimidation +7, Religion +6

Senses: passive Perception 13

Languages: Common, Old Imperial (academy-perfect), Tarnovari, Dwarvish

Challenge: 9 (5,000 XP)

Sanction of the Broken Word. Dregan's weapon attacks deal an extra 9 (2d8) radiant damage against any creature that has knowingly broken a sworn oath. (DM adjudication — and the grim joke is that against bandits, deserters, and most of the fractured world's soldiery, everyone qualifies. His power works almost everywhere he points it. He has noticed. It is part of what he is becoming.)

Vow of Enmity (1/Day). Bonus action: advantage on attack rolls against one creature for 1 minute.

Aura of the Stakes. Enemies within 10 feet of Dregan who have broken a sworn oath have disadvantage on saving throws against being frightened.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Dregan makes three attacks with his hooked warpick.

Hooked Warpick. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (1d10 + 4) piercing damage (plus Sanction where it applies).

The Question (1/Day). Dregan speaks a zone of truth (DC 15) centered on himself, phrased as courtesy. He has never needed to raise his voice inside one.

Sea-King Aldrec the Landless

Medium humanoid (human, Skell), chaotic neutral — Fighter (raider-king, dying)

Armor Class: 16 (breastplate, sea-worn)

Hit Points: 105 (17d8 + 34)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)	17 (+3)

Saving Throws: Str +7, Con +5

Skills: Athletics +7, History +5, Intimidation +6, Persuasion +6

Senses: passive Perception 11

Languages: Common (courtly, better than most courtiers'), Skell

Challenge: 7 (2,900 XP)

The Old Wound. Aldrec is dying, and the block says so: while below half his hit points, at the start of each of his turns he must succeed on a DC 12 Constitution saving throw or take only one action that turn. His housecarls know the tell — the way his hand finds his side — and close ranks without being told.

Tally-Law. Aldrec has advantage on Insight and Persuasion checks in any negotiation where terms, debts, or oaths are at issue. He counts silently in Skell when angry.

Tide-Roar (Recharge 5–6). A war-shout in a 30-foot cone: each creature must succeed on a DC 15 Constitution saving throw or be deafened and pushed 10 feet (ships' crews have lost boarding actions to the voice alone).

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Aldrec makes three greataxe attacks.

Greataxe ("Collection"). Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 10 (1d12 + 4) slashing damage. The haft is scored with tally-marks. He can tell you what each one is for.

Duke Garvin Norr, the Bastard of Normere

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral — Fighter (mastermind-general)

Armor Class: 17 (half plate, unadorned)

Hit Points: 120 (18d8 + 39)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	13 (+1)	15 (+2)	18 (+4)	15 (+2)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws: Con +5, Int +7

Skills: History +7, Insight +5, Investigation +7

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Common, Old Imperial, Normerine ledger-cant

Challenge: 8 (3,900 XP)

The Reckoning. Against any creature Norr has observed for one minute, or any creature sworn to him, his attacks gain advantage and deal an extra 9 (2d8) damage — he fights the

way he governs: with complete information. He recites your capabilities aloud as he closes, in a flat voice, from memory.

Terms Offered. Once per combat (free action), Norr states surrender terms. They are exact, survivable, and he will keep them to the letter. Creatures that accept are bound; creatures that refuse grant his allies +1 to attack rolls against them for 1 minute (the Duke's men fight harder against the unreasonable).

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Norr makes three warhammer attacks.

Warhammer. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (1d10 + 4) bludgeoning damage.

REACTIONS

Commander's Stroke. When an ally within 30 feet misses an attack, Norr grants an immediate reroll (3/day). He does not say 'again.' He says the correction.

King Karvel of Ardven

Medium humanoid (human), lawful good — Fighter (Champion, crowned)

Armor Class: 18 (plate, northern-worked)

Hit Points: 127 (15d10 + 45)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	17 (+3)

Saving Throws: Str +8, Con +6

Skills: Athletics +8, Persuasion +6, Religion +4 (loud, slightly wrong)

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Ardvenner, Common, Orlathine liturgical (mispronounced with confidence)

Challenge: 8 (3,900 XP)

Crowned Presence. Each creature of Karvel's choice within 30 feet that sees him fight must succeed on a DC 15 Wisdom saving throw or be unable to willingly move away from him for 1 minute — not fear: gravity. Men follow him off cliffs. It is how he made a kingdom.

The Audit. Karvel has advantage on Insight checks against anyone reporting numbers to him. He sleeps four hours. He has personally caught nineteen reeves.

Sweep (Recharge 5–6). Karvel swings through every creature in a 10-foot arc: DC 16 Dexterity save, 18 (4d8) slashing on a failure, half on success.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Karvel makes three greatsword attacks.

Greatsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 12 (2d6 + 5) slashing damage. Critical on 19–20.

Saint-Regent Olvesa the Reconciled

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral — Cleric (Life; true visions)

Armor Class: 13 (sanctified vestments — she has not worn armor in nearly sixty years)

Hit Points: 117 (18d8 + 36)

Speed: 25 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	10 (+0)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)	20 (+5)	17 (+3)

Saving Throws: Wis +9, Cha +7

Skills: History +6, Insight +9, Medicine +9, Religion +6

Senses: passive Perception 15

Languages: Orlathine, Common, Old Imperial, Drevic (she has not spoken it aloud in sixty years)

Challenge: 10 (5,900 XP)

The Reconciled. A creature that attempts to attack Olvesa directly must first succeed on a DC 17 Wisdom saving throw (as sanctuary, permanent, self-only) — not divine protection, exactly: the full weight of looking at her and knowing everything she has done and everything she became afterward. On a success, the creature is immune for 24 hours. She has been struck four times in nearly sixty years. She remembers each one kindly.

True Visions. Olvesa casts as a 13th-level cleric (spell save DC 17): spirit guardians (appearing as gray wolves), flame strike (she weeps when she casts it — the birds), heal, greater restoration, divination — and her divinations are TRUE, which is the entire geopolitical problem.

The Four Movements (DM only). If the campaign ever requires Olvesa at war rather than at prayer, do not build it as a fight. Build it as a horror scene with a stat block attached. She has not forgotten how. That is what the Reconciliation is FOR.

ACTIONS

Shepherd's Crook. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage. It is a walking stick. She is eighty.

Mistress Averil Shen

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral — Rogue (Mastermind)

Armor Class: 15 (studded leather under gray wool)

Hit Points: 84 (13d8 + 26)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	18 (+4)	14 (+2)	18 (+4)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws: Dex +7, Int +7

Skills: Deception +8, Insight +9, Investigation +10, Perception +6, Sleight of Hand +7, Stealth +10

Senses: passive Perception 16

Languages: Common, Old Imperial, four provincial tongues, three ciphers of her own devising

Challenge: 6 (2,300 XP)

Stillness. Shen has advantage on initiative rolls and can't be surprised while conscious. She has been the calmest person in every room she has ever entered, including this one.

Sneak Attack (5d6). Once per turn, +17 damage against a target she has advantage against or that is engaged with an ally (the Gull counts; the Gull is always somewhere).

Evasion / Uncanny Dodge. As the rogue features.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Shen makes two shortsword attacks (or one, and disappears — Cunning Action).

Letter-Opener (Shortsword). Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (1d6 + 4) piercing damage, plus Sneak Attack where it applies. It is, genuinely, her letter-opener.

REACTIONS

Uncanny Dodge. Halve the damage of one attack that hits her. She will thank the attacker afterward, sincerely, for the information.

Prelate Sarvin Odell

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral — Cleric (Knowledge)

Armor Class: 14 (chain shirt under gray robes)

Hit Points: 78 (12d8 + 24)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	17 (+3)	18 (+4)	15 (+2)

Saving Throws: Wis +7, Int +6

Skills: History +6, Insight +10, Investigation +6, Religion +9

Senses: passive Perception 14

Languages: Common, Old Imperial, Celestial (liturgical)

Challenge: 5 (1,800 XP)

The File. Odell has advantage on Insight checks against any creature on whom his office holds a file, and he may substitute Religion for Insight when examining claims of divine contact. Assume the file exists.

Spellcasting. 9th-level cleric (spell save DC 15): zone of truth, hold person, tongues, dispel magic, and — his signature — the Invocation of the Sealed Record (as modify memory, used exactly twice in thirty years, both times lawfully, both times filed).

Never By Argument (DM note). Odell's combat statistics are his least relevant numbers. He is beaten by law, by politics, or by the collapse of his case — never by debate and worse than never by violence. If a party attacks him, they have already lost something they cannot get back.

ACTIONS

Weighted Blessing (Mace). Melee Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage (nonlethal, invariably).

Sacred Flame. One creature within 60 feet: DC 15 Dexterity save or 13 (3d8) radiant damage. He apologizes first.

Block	DMG Band Check (AC / HP / Atk)	Deviation & Role Justification
Shen (CR 6)	15 / 84 (84–140, floor) / +7	Assassin-profile: burst (sneak attack) meets band on opener, under sustained — standard rogue NPC shape (cf. SRD Assassin, CR 8, same pattern).
Odell (CR 5)	14 / 78 (71–119) / DC 15 — in band	Control-role cleric; DPR deliberately trivial. His CR prices his spells and saves, not his mace.

DESIGN VALIDATION NOTES

Block	DMG Band Check (AC / HP / Atk)	Deviation & Role Justification
Qilvayas (CR 9)	18 / 123 (band 109–181) / +8 — all in band	DPR under band: sovereign-support design (aura, 45-pt heal pool, Interposition). Fights defensively by nature and theme.
Thorne (CR 10)	18 / 143 (116–194) / +9 — in band	DPR under band: commander archetype trades damage for battlefield control (maneuvers, Riposte, Ashline) — same pattern as SRD leader-type NPCs.
Dane (CR 7)	18 / 110 (98–162) / +7 — in band	AC above band (plate, knight-standard, RAW). DPR reaches band only with For the Ninth! — leader-aura carries the rest.
Dregan (CR 9)	17 / 130 / +8 — in band	DPR ON band (55) vs. oath-breakers via Sanction; below vs. the innocent — which is the character.
Aldrec (CR 7)	16 / 105 / +7 — in band	DPR under band; Old Wound actively reduces output. Deliberate: a dying king should fight like one.
Norr (CR 8)	17 / 120 (102–170) / +7 — in band	DPR reaches band vs. Reckoned targets (~40). Information-warfare design.
Karvel (CR 8)	18 / 127 / +8 — in band	DPR band-low + Sweep; Crowned Presence is the real weapon.
Olvesa (CR 10)	13 / 117 (116–194, floor) / DC 17	AC far under band — control/support caster protected by the Reconciled (sanctuary-class defense replaces armor). Flame strike AoE meets damage expectations at half-per-target rule.

APPENDIX III — HOMEBREW ITEMS OF RECORD

Dren's Oath-Medallion (wondrous, uncommon, unique): A defaced legion oath-medallion, permanently cold, undetectable as magical. While carried openly, the bearer feels it grow colder in the presence of significant oath-breaking, active shadow-residue, or thin-written ground — no mechanics, only truth. It is quieter (Vaelindra's word) in the keeping of those who keep their word.

Oathstone Charm (wondrous, common — Tarnovari): A thumb-sized standing stone on a cord, sworn over at carving. Once per day, when the bearer hears a sworn statement, they may gain advantage on one Insight check to judge its sincerity. Sold openly in Kamenhold; the Stonesworn consider selling them to foreigners either diplomacy or a very long joke.

Pilgrim's Wolfstone (wondrous, common — Church): A shrine-blessed river pebble bearing the Matron's eye. While carried, wolves and dogs regard the bearer as neutral unless provoked, and the bearer knows true north on a clear night. Lupenna sells thousands; perhaps one in forty is 'live.' The Church insists they all are, in the way that matters.

Wardstone Shard (wondrous, common — unique source): A fist-sized fragment of the First Seal's dead wardline. Sheds dim wolf-grey light in a 10-foot radius — and gutters, unmistakably, within 30 feet of Undercourt cold. A canary made of history.

The Lector's Seal (wondrous, rare, unique — the company's stamp): The recovered archival master-key, gifted as the company's sealing-stamp (canon). Documents sealed with it read as genuinely authorized to any mundane inspection within the academy's records system, and the seal cannot be forged — its wax remembers. (Limits: academy archives and their dependencies only; it opens paper, not doors; and every use is, somewhere in the deep stacks, logged.)

DEVELOPMENT ROADMAP

— POST-BETA STATUS

The D&D-ification pass and the Social Foundations pass are both complete: all names canonical; the Founding Myth, binding site, timeline, both campaign clocks, and the Powers locked; magic and the faith codified (the Weight of the Word, the Sanction, Chartered Thaumaturgy, the night iconography, lycanthropy doctrine, the relic economy); peoples and demographics established (the Founder's Blood, the Stonesworn, the Marked, and the rest); every region fleshed with terrain, creatures, and settlements; three dragon-powers placed; the Roster assigned; ten Powers fully statted (Appendix II); five homebrew items of record (Appendix III); and commerce and loot grounded in SRD pricing; the Packlaw doctrine of gender and authority; the four-tier framework for oaths, service, and bound labor; marriage-as-oath and the Denmother's Choice succession custom; and the twelve-month Imperial Calendar. Closed since: a full timeline-arithmetic audit across every document, reconciling the commencement clock, the dynasty's short reigns, and the Acceleration's dating; and the imperial law pass — the Zhuvedian Laws in seven Books, the Sanction and the Charter's mark-and-register certification, the jurisdiction map from Direct Rule to warlord country, the legions' rank ladder (and Marshal reframed as an acclamation rather than a rung on it), street-level justice from provincial magistrate to the Church's parallel Writ, and the Golden Tablets quoted in fragment for the first time; and the language and literacy pass — Old Imperial fully dead as a native tongue, literacy tracking education and office rather than region, and the exposure the unlettered face under the new Laws' witness-and-register requirements; and the currency, named at last — the Zhuven, which almost nobody calls a Zhuven; and medicine and disease — the tiered-care system Book Three already implied, the uncertified folk layer beneath it, and Farrowgate's Damp as the sharpened, deliberately mundane case. This closes every item on the social-gaps list. Newly framed, and deliberately live rather than closed: the Marked's legal personhood — Book One's one unresolved clause, now built out with its full theological and practical texture, resolution handed to the Branch Ledger and tied to the Twin Clocks' Solacre promulgation. Newly designed alongside it: the Twin Clocks arc itself — Solacre Day's convergence of the Marked ruling, the Grey-Gold Rising, and word of Karvel's coronation into a single set piece; the Rising's trigger identified as Book Three's registration requirement extended over Long Course commerce rather than a new tax; and its mercy-or-massacre outcome live and tied to the Branch Ledger, the same mechanism as Marked personhood. Also closed since: the titles pass — five parallel ladders rather than one order of precedence, the Matriarchate established as collegial with a Prelate holding his writ from the Synod rather than from the Matron's Voice, Saint-Regent given its referent at last as the See's regency of the True Rite for a throne it holds vacant, and Academy faculty restyled Professor so the title stops colliding with the civil Magistrate; and a full pre-launch consistency audit across all eleven documents — Solacre Day reconciled to one convergent day in every timeline that states it, the Suthmark's governance separated into law and fact with the Dowager's sons entered as canon, the Zhuven put into the mouths of the people who actually spend it, and Book Three's register requirement carried into the party's own charter. That audit included the corpus's first mechanical validation against the SRD — thirty-two homebrew stat blocks, the ten Powers among them, every spell reference and every price — which found no genuine

errors, and one scaling curve since corrected. Closed since, in the published-scale expansion: the faith's remaining half, which two centuries of schism had left implied rather than written — the Doctrine of Aspects, the seven the Matriarchate recognizes, the domains for which the empire deliberately has no Aspect at all, the three paladin oaths placed against existing institutions, and a canon of fourteen saints with feast days keyed to the calendar already in this book; and Standing, the six-tier record of what twelve institutions remember about a company, with its opposed pairs and its one faction whose favor is a liability. Published alongside this volume, and derived from it rather than rivalling it: a Gazetteer keying thirty settlements across the ten regions, with travel, hazards, regional encounter tables, and eight creatures the empire has that the manual does not; and a Player's Companion carrying backgrounds, names, downtime, and the faith as a worshipper meets it. Deliberately open by design (not gaps): Nyreeza's exact fate; Countess Ory's blood-rite mechanism; the coronation's metaphysical consequence; whether the Piso gun over Marshal Dane ever fires; whether any line of Threnvos survives; and warlock patron design (sign-off required when built — at least one patron option may trace to the thing beneath Aenodira).

Next development priorities, in order:

1. The Undercourt and the Binding Site: COMPLETE.

Sessions Seven and Eight build the full descent — the price of the Seal, the Vesting Room, the Long Approach, the Witness Hall, and the Rite Floor — through the Vigil and the separation of grief from hunger. The campaign's next frontier is the second arc: the empire itself.

2. Tarnovar Deep Development: Well advanced (Kamenhold, Fencegate, Verath, the Stonesworn, the Old Wood) — still needs the Vosthren ballad cycle in full and the Voivode's court before the envoy thread matures into an arc.

3. The Twin Clocks: DESIGNED. Solacre Day now runs as one convergent set piece — the Marked ruling, the Grey-Gold Rising, and word of Karvel's coronation landing together (see Plot Hooks). The Rising's trigger is Book Three's registration requirement extended over Long Course commerce, not a new tax; its mercy-or-massacre outcome is live, tracked on the Branch Ledger exactly like Marked personhood. Still deliberately deferred: the coronation's metaphysical consequence, held until the arc is actually on the table. What remains is building the actual session.

4. The Greywell Module: The Girls of Greywell as a self-contained gothic horror arc (seeded via Session Five's optional Farrowgate client); decide Ory's mechanism at build time.

5. Sessions Nine and Beyond: Built against party divergences recorded in the DM Reference Guide's Branch Ledger.

6. Setting Feats and Subclasses: Deliberately not built. The Player's Companion stops at backgrounds and flavour, entirely inside 2014 RAW, so that nothing in it needs balancing before it can be used. An Oath of the Witness and a Domain of the Vigil are the obvious candidates and both want real playtest before they are canon — a signed-off pass of their own, not an addendum to this one.

7. Art in the Published Documents: The images directory serves the repository and not yet the corpus. Getting artwork into the documents means an image path added to both the docx-js generation and the Markdown shim, across nine generators — a deliberate later pass, and one worth doing once there is enough art to justify it.

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"We are the Kin of Great Timberwolf"